

ralph

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GIRLS
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Editor's Letter

Hello!

Welcome to this, the fourth issue of *Ralph*.

A year ago, we set out to make a quarterly magazine, so this issue means we've completed our first cycle. Hooray!

It's yet another packed issue – I'm really proud that we're getting a reputation not just for being a really fun pop culture publication, but that *Ralph* is always full-to-bursting of interesting, global stories.

So, here's what's in this one, deep breath... we've got the incredible comedian/actor/podcaster Tim Heidecker and actor/producer/model Marta Pozzan on the cover. They're the stars of new indie film *Fior Di Latte*, and they talk us through the unusual filming, how the film has affected them as artists and why we should stop waiting for permission to do things and just make the stuff you want (exactly what we do at *Ralph*).

Elsewhere in the magazine, we knew that hip-hop icon Chuck D was also an accomplished artist, so we asked him to give us a guided tour of his favourite paintings, we spent the night at the infamous Muscle Girls bar in Tokyo, caught up with Ahilya Bamroo and Anasuya Sangupta – two Indian actors with unusual routes to the silver screen, went to Russell T Davies' favourite *Doctor Who*-themed cabaret, and got silly with top comedian and filmmaker Jamali Maddix. We also review time itself, wonder what disco actually is in 2025, learn how to present with Harriet Rose and absolutely loads more.

So here you go, *Ralph* #4 - Pop Culture For The Fun Of It

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GO HARD OR GO HOME

Goths, sandwiches, Japan and music with hard life

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Drinkwater Studio



What do you do when your band's absolutely smashing it, you've played the Pyramid Stage at Glastonbury and Alexandra Palace in London, had two #2-charting albums, collaborated with Arlo Parks, Kevin Abstract and FINNEAS, but then a mega-massive-global-corporation takes exception to your band name and wants to take you to court?

Well, you have a torrid time and then change the name of the band, move to Japan, write new music, bang out a brand new album and look forward to hitting the hedonistic times of playing at festivals again this summer... That's exactly what Murray Matravers did with his band, anyway. Now called hard life (lower case intentional), we figured to help him ease back into doing press and talking about albums rather than court cases, we'd ask him a bunch of very Ralphie questions.

Hey Murray... 'It's My Life' by Bon Jovi, 'Good Life' by Inner City or 'Hard Knock Life' by Jay-Z?

'It's My Life' by Bon Jovi because sometimes you just need to scream this at the top of your lungs, butt naked doing the hoovering.

What's more powerful: a goth or a rockabilly?
Goth. They are hot af.

What's the best sandwich?
Teriyaki Egg from Lawson. iykyk.

What's the most intriguing thing about living in Japan?

There are NO bins and yet at the same time NO litter. We have bins everywhere in London and still we manage to make the place look a mess. The Japanese are just built differently. They will carry their rubbish around with them all day until they are home and then separate it into burnable, recyclable etc. Imagine asking a British person to do that – they would laugh in your face.

How has living there affected your songwriting?

I am never allowed to be truly comfortable – I'll always be an outsider and don't speak the language. I have become pretty fluent in the way things run out there but I'll always be on edge. I like this feeling – it makes me feel alive. I'm convinced Tokyo makes me write better songs.

"I'm convinced Tokyo makes me write better songs"



What's the funniest lyric of all time?

It has to be when Eminem is talking about putting a gerbil up his ass in 'FACK'. Enough said.

What song on your new record most sums up being in hard life?

'Tears'... because I'm always crying.

Do you need a tissue? The lead track off the album, 'othello' is a reference to the super strategic board game. Are you any good at chess?

I love chess but I'm not very good. A friend of mine is super into it and reads books and studies it etc. One day he will be one of those Grand Master wizard-type shit. I, however, am a lot more casual with it. I think the best thing about chess is the way it looks – it's super aesthetic.

Which Shakespearean character are you most like?

Romeo, duh.

If you had to describe the new record to big Billy Shakespeare himself in no more than 10 words, what would you say?

Let thine ears partake, lest thou miss thef hidden glory... *olofin*



THE GALLIFREY CABARET

Who knew that *Doctor Who* could get even camper?

Words by Ben Smoke
Photos by James Klug



Did you know that the name of the home planet of the Slitheen, a particularly gassy, verdant alien first featured in a 2005 episode of *Doctor Who*, fits almost perfectly into the chorus of Lady Gaga's 'Abracadabra'? Try it with me now! "Raxacoricofallapatorius, in her tongue she said, death or love tonight!"

Now, you might be asking how could I possibly have come into possession of this information? Is there an encyclopaedic knowledge of the 889 instalments of the beloved children's sci-fi show wedged somewhere in my brain?

Alas, no. My own personal journey with the show started and ended in 2005, when, aged 14, I had to suffer the indignity of crawling into bed with my mum because I was so scared from the episode where children in gas masks wander around Blitz London asking all and sundry "are you my mummy?"

There are many millions though, who stuck with it. Now in its 15th series after being rebooted by *Queer as Folk* creator Russell T Davies in 2005, the iconic BBC show has been fronted by 15 doctors, featured dozens of companions and encountered approximately 300 different species of aliens since it first appeared on screens in 1963.

It takes a very specific type of mind to be able to see the syllabic symmetry between the chorus of a 2025 pop song and a fictional far-off planet referenced in a show 20 years previously. And that is where Reece Connolly and Carrot come in. Performers, artists and producers living in London, the pair are the brains behind the *Gallifrey Cabaret* – a *Doctor Who* themed queer cabaret hosted at the auspicious Clapham Grand theatre in south London.

"We've always loved *Doctor Who*, it's part of how we got together," Reece tells me. We sat on the stage at the Clapham Grand for the interview, the ornate arch of the Victorian music hall stretching up to the heavens above

us. "We first bonded over the show as friends and then [dramatic pause] as lovers. We were already producing lots of work so I said maybe we should do a *Doctor Who*-themed cabaret, just as a one off."

"I never thought it would sell," admits drag artist Carrot. "I was just like no, that's a terrible idea, no-one's going to come to that, don't be stupid. So I was... wrong." They look around to the empty boxes and tiers of seats reaching up to the vaulted ceiling that just a few weeks before, were packed to the rafters with devoted 'Whovians', eagerly awaiting the show.

The *Gallifrey Cabaret* is unlike anything you've ever seen before. Stripping Daleks. Companions on rope swings. A cat rapping Nicki Minaj's 'Monster' verse. It's a very specific type of fever dream – one you're sure you don't want to wake up from. The *Cabaret* started in 2021 as a one-off show at the Royal Vauxhall Tavern, one of the oldest queer venues in London.

From there it has snowballed, with each sold-out iteration of the show now seeing over 700 people cramming into the Grand. There have been special guests as part of the show – my ears have only just stopped ringing from the noise that erupted when fan favourite of the TV show, K-9 appeared on stage to help judge the costume competition.

One such audience member, who attended last year's Christmas edition of the *Cabaret* is current (and past) *Doctor Who* show-runner Russell T Davies, who tells me, "I came to *Gallifrey Cabaret* as an observer, and left a fanatic. They got me! The most glorious room full of imagination and joy and community. Truly, I found the whole thing profoundly moving, even as a Christmas tree chased a drag Jackie Tyler around the stage. It was like finding a really queer space in the sense of queer meaning other – gay,

**"We always say
Gallifrey is a show
by queer fans, for
queer fans"**





straight, anyone, all gathered with the same sensibility, to have as much fun as possible based on a mad old TV show. And so creative! I hope the people who run *Doctor Who* in the future were in that room. Long live Reece and Carrot, long live the *Gallifrey Cabaret*!"

It's that sense of 'other', so madly and magically captured in the *Gallifrey Cabaret*, that drew Reece and Carrot to the TV show. "The *Doctor Who* fandom and franchise is very queer-coded and has been pretty much, from the very beginning back in the '60s, but certainly has been since it came back onto our TVs in 2005 under Russell's premiership," Reece tells me.

"What we didn't realise is there was a big gap that needed to be filled," Carrot says. "There are a lot of *Doctor Who* events and panels and talk shows, and that sort of thing, but not a lot of stuff that's actually entertaining."

"Sci-fi franchises that have been running for a certain number of years, are very dominated by straight white men," Reece concludes. "What we've worked really, really hard to do is to create a space this is safe for and inclusive of people who aren't straight white men (not that there's anything wrong with that etc). We always say *Gallifrey* is a show by queer fans, for queer fans."

Recently, that space has felt even more necessary than usual. Even the most casual observer will have seen the kickback from certain sections of the internet against the show in the last few years. It started with the furore around Jodie Whittaker's 13th Doctor being the first female doctor, with many angry that a shapeshifting alien with two hearts, who travels through space and time in a police box that's bigger on the inside than the outside, could have had the temerity to regenerate with a vagina.

The casting of Ncuti Gatwa, who rose to fame after an excellent turn as Eric in

Netflix's *Sex Education* prompted more shouting and screaming from the most boring corners of the internet. This time upset that a shapeshifting alien with two hearts, who travels through space and time... [We get it - Ed.] had the audacity to be regenerated as black and queer. Rumours bubble away around the internet that Disney, who have acquired the franchise, is on the cusp of canning the show because of the backlash.

As an outsider of this fandom, it strikes me as weird, I posit to Reece and Carrot, that fans of a show about the liquidity of identity, about searching for solace and safety in a chosen family and, let's be honest here, really gay aliens, would react like that.

"I think it's actually a minority of people who are just very loud and are just sort of trying to be incendiary," Reece muses. "The vast majority of viewers and fans are very supportive and welcoming of the otherness and self-expression and freedom at the core of a show like *Doctor Who*."

"This is a character who escaped from their stuffy home planet in a ship that can travel anywhere and they choose their own family and friends, which is also a sort of universal queer experience," he adds.

And travel the Doctor (who I am reliably informed is just called "the Doctor", and not 'Doctor Who') does. With more than five decades of source material to work with in a cabaret show that features props, special effects, surprise guests, video, and more, I ask how the pair manage to cope – how they don't get overwhelmed by the sheer magnitude of it all?

"We don't really think about it – we just sort of start throwing ideas around," Reece explains. "And from there we start building the thing. If you look at it as a mountain that needs to be climbed, I think we would both probably get too scared because there is so much to do!"

Each show starts with a broad narrative. The pair pick characters, moments and stories from across the universe they want to feature and then start thinking about who they want to play those characters.

As for the ideas for the actual acts? Sometimes the performers come with an idea and other times, like in the case of Guinness World Record hula hooper, Luspinda (who guest starred as Jodie Whittaker's 13th Doctor at *Gallifrey* back in April), the acts arrive perfectly formed in Reece and Carrot's minds. It is, they tell me, a huge collaboration between them, the performers, stage managers and the staff at the venue.

There is one unifying theme (beyond *Doctor Who* of course) in this giant cross scene/practice/universe collaboration played out on the stage of the Clapham Grand. Silliness.

I ask how important it is to be able to be silly with something they love so much. How that silliness fits into the creation of space and safety that they say is so integral to the life of the show.

"It is a silly thing and we embrace that," Reece says. "But things can be silly and also be serious and heartbreaking at the same time, because that's what life is. Especially at the moment, or even over the four or five years we've been doing the show, the world has only continued to get more terrifying and weird and inexplicable and *Gallifrey* feels like a play where people can find a bit of escapism. Being silly is one of the best ways to let go."

"A lot of the time with the TV show, the way they make it feel more relatable is through silliness," Carrot adds. "It's the moments of comedy in *Doctor Who* that makes people feel so emotionally connected to it a lot of the time. I don't think you'd get as invested in quite a serious topic like, for example, the destruction of the Doctor's home planet, if there wasn't lots of human moments for you to relate to them with."

It's this forging of the serious and silly, the lamentable and the ludicrous that enthral audiences so much. It's also what allows them to utilise the space and their stage to raise funds and awareness about issues that could not be further from silly.

At the beginning of the final act of the show, a raffle is drawn, with prizes that include signed scripts, merch and more. Proceeds from the raffle tickets, which were sold throughout the show, raised money for Cabaret Versus Cancer.

"We've both been ambassadors of Cabaret Versus Cancer for about three years," Carrot told me. "It's an amazing charity which has been running for about a decade, and they support research into cancer treatments and grassroots charities who help those who have been affected by cancer."

"We've both had experience of cancer in our families, as I'm sure sadly most people have," Reece adds on the decision to partner with the charity since their first show. The charity was founded and run by Rose Thorne – an "incredible little Scottish stick of dynamite" and, through their ambassadorship with the charity, which has seen thousands raised through their shows, both have had the opportunity to see some of the vital work they do.

"I went to visit Saint John's Hospice, which is a place that Cabaret Versus Cancer have a very close relationship with and who work exclusively with kids who are going through bereavement," Reece recounts. "They create these amazing resources and activity days and stuff that helps them through that time."

The charity, which as the name may suggest, works with performers across the scene, also provides specific and targeted support to LGBTQ people and other minority groups affected by cancer.

"The most glorious room full of imagination and joy and community. Truly, I found the whole thing profoundly moving, even as a Christmas tree chased a drag Jackie Tyler around the stage"

Russell T Davies

On the surface the *Gallifrey Cabaret* is a raucous, unrelentingly stupid three hours of your life you would happily give up again and again. That I, a man who gave up on the franchise two decades ago, could sit and belly laugh along knowing next to nothing about what was actually happening on stage, should speak to the calibre of performance on offer.

Even more than that though, in its heart, or to be anatomically accurate, in its two hearts, the *Gallifrey Cabaret* represents hope. It represents fun and silliness and play in a world that increasingly seems to want to shut it down. An escape that, though from the outside seems small in the grand scheme of things, represents infinite possibility within. *ralph*



BILLY BARRATT BANTS

Chatting horror films, YouTube, music and more
with one of Britain's hottest young actors.

Words by Hannah Strong
Photos by Stefan Bertin

A starring role in Danny and Michael Philippou's hotly tipped A24 horror Bring Her Back, the youngest actor to win an International Emmy Award, and a second residency for his band The Hunger at London's legendary Sebright Arms - 18-year-old multi-hyphenate Billy Barratt's 2025 is as hectic as they come. He couldn't be more excited. Ralph caught up with him at London's Thin White Duke bar and recording studios to get the lowdown on his whirlwind career.

You started acting professionally pretty young. What appealed to you about it?

Yeah, I started when I was about seven years old, because my mum's friend was an up-and-coming director and she had this film that she was doing called *To Dream*. I never read the script or anything like that, but I just got asked "Do you want to be in a flashback scene?" And I thought, why not? It was good fun and my mum saw that I really enjoyed it and liked being in front of the camera and the attention. She got me an audition for an agency and from there it sort of took off. But I only really started knowing what film actually was and really paying attention to the actual craft and appreciating the whole thing, when I was about 12 or 13, when I did the film *Responsible Child*. That's when I began to realise what I was actually doing and that this is a job and that it's also a really great job.

It's wild to me that you had a whole job at 13. I was still playing with dolls.

It's wild to me as well! Especially with *Responsible Child*, because it was really heavy material, and everyone thinks I must have come away from it really traumatised, but I was totally fine! I had some really cool people on set with me, who helped me get out of character, which really is needed, in my opinion. The person that helped me most was acting coach Miranda Harcourt, who I actually just worked with again on *Bring Her Back*. She was amazing - still is amazing. My chaperone was great too - they just gave me someone to talk to and someone to sort of bring me back to reality.

Speaking of *Bring Her Back*, Danny and Michael Phillipou's first film was a massive hit. Had you seen their feature directorial debut *Talk To Me* before you auditioned for this film?

Well, actually, I was already a massive fan of RackaRacka Boys when they were doing that... [*The horror comedy YouTube channel Danny and Michael Phillipou had before making Talk To Me*].

You were an OG fan!

Oh yeah, me and all my friends were like the biggest RackaRacka fans. And then just after *Responsible Child* came out, I got a call from them, which was insane. I was like, "What? Like, you guys are calling me?" and they wanted me to do *Talk to Me*. But it didn't end up working out, I think because it was during Covid and they were shooting in Australia. But then they called about *Bring Her Back*, I did a couple of auditions and they obviously thought I was right for the role of Andy. We went out to Australia and shot it for three months, and it was one of the greatest experiences of my life. And I don't say that about every film I've ever done!

It feels like it was destiny then.

Yeah, and they gave us all these rings as wrap gifts [*holds up his hand to show a gold ring*] which have a drawing from the film on. I haven't actually taken this off since we wrapped apart from when I'm shooting.

How did you find shooting a film as gory and brutal as *Bring Her Back*? I'm always curious if being behind the scenes makes it less scary.

I thought I was going to be really shitting my pants the whole time shooting it. I've auditioned for horror before, and my mum was like "No, don't do it, it's too much!" but Danny and Michael, these boys are so humble and down to earth, but they also know what they want and what they need. The RackaRacka boys never get tired. When all



the scary stuff is happening on set – the really sort of gruesome, gory shit, the whole crew sort of just made it a really nice environment to be in. When they're doing a gruesome gory thing, someone would crack a joke after it and it just sort of made things normal again. But they were also great at, say, when you're doing a really sad emotional scene or even like a really happy scene, the crew would match that energy. I'm like, "okay, I can now just get into this moment and do this scene." And it's like we were all in it together, which you are on every set, but it doesn't always feel like that. This was the most unbelievable set to be working on.

You saw the finished film for the first time yesterday – what did you think?

I was going in there thinking "Aargh, I'm not going to know if it's a good film or not." Because I'm thinking about my performance the whole time, y'know? Wondering why I did something or thinking I could have done a bit better. So it's a bit weird, but you just end up sort of forgetting it's you. It's a character in a story. It's sort of surreal, but yeah, I loved it. And getting to see Jonah [Wren Phillips] and Sora [Wong] too, they were amazing. They absolutely killed it.

I have to ask you about your band, The Hunger. How did you come together? And are you named after the 1983 vampire film, starring David Bowie?

Yeah we are! Me and Cody Molko, we went to school together and we didn't get on at all. I thought he was a little prick. [laughs] But then he ended up actually being really sweet and he sort of took me in with his group in school. A lot of people didn't really like that, but Cody always defended me and I really appreciated that. Then I saw a video of Green Day in Chicago in 1996 or 1994. It's where Billie Joe Armstrong's just going crazy, and it just made me really want to be in a band. I knew that Cody could play guitar and drums, and pretty much everything to a certain extent, so I asked him: "Do you want to be in a band?" He said he was already in one. So I asked him again like a month later, and

he said, no – he ended up saying no three times before he finally said, "Yeah, all right, let's try it." We wrote a song about walking into a lamp post and it was really bad. But we kept going and eventually we got some good tunes. One of them's actually in *Bring Her Back*. Bruno Ben-Tovim's our bassist and went to our school. We didn't know that he could play an instrument until the final year of school. We were like, "Where have you been?!" He's actually better than both of us combined. Then Millie Taylor, our drummer, thank God we got her because she's amazing.

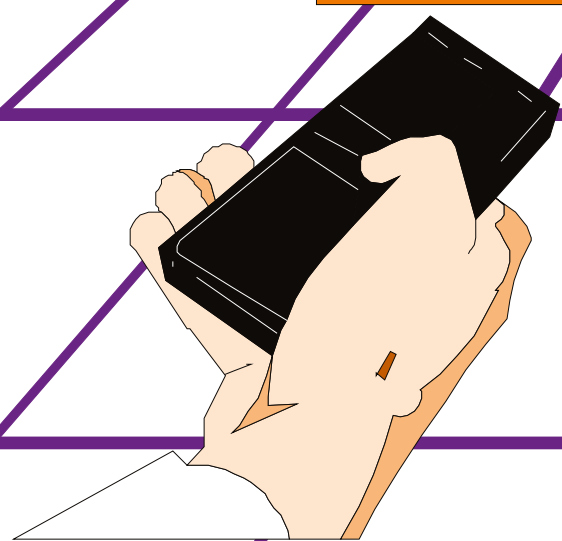
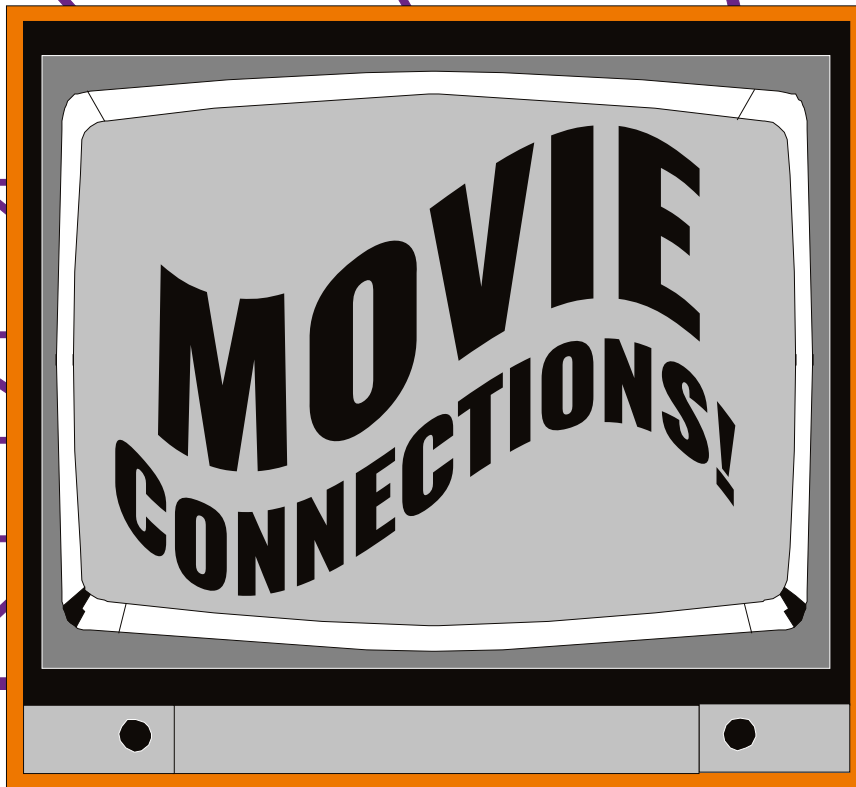
You've just done a residency at London indie music venue, Sebright Arms, and you have another planned. How has that been?

I love the Sebright Arms, it's like the TARDIS. You think the pub's small then you go downstairs and it's just awesome. It gets hot though, I asked them to turn the air-con off once and by the end of the set I really wish I'd kept it on. But the crowd got sweaty and just started running into each other and just having a good time. I love seeing people there without their phones out. We have this guy called Joe Horsford, he gets on stage and he's like our best mate, went to school with us, and he gets on stage and goes crazy.

Like Bez from Happy Mondays?

Yeah, Bez without the maracas. So Joe, he'd been at every single show that we'd played, just going crazy and being our hype man, but he couldn't make our last gig. We were really nervous about it because we were going to play his song where he gets on stage and goes for it. So just before I shouted, "Who wants to get on stage?" and then suddenly everyone's on stage with us. We're playing the fastest, punkiest tune we've got. It was just chaos. I love acting, but with music, it's different because you've actually written it yourself, you've sat in your room, writing whatever song, and then you get on stage and fucking loads of people are singing it back to you. It's a crazy, next level feeling. I love it. I love it so much. *ralph*





It's not all about Kevin Bacon. There are other ways to connect things, you know? We had a few spare minutes in the office so we made you a quiz: Can you work out what connects these films?

1. Mrs Doubtfire

FACE/OFF

Trainspotting

2. Trainwreck

Vertigo

3. The Long Kiss Goodnight

Babe

4. Candyman

Milk

5. The French Connection

6. Desperado

The Italian Job

7. Summer Holiday

Cliffhanger

8. The Dark Knight

Planes, Trains and Automobiles

- Answers
- 1. Someone tears their own face off and everyone's kind of OK with that
 - 2. Nothing to do with trains
 - 3. What incels want more than anything
 - 4. Candy
 - 5. Smuggling is cool
 - 6. Things our editor would only drink at a house party if there was nothing else
 - 7. Cliffs are vital cast members
 - 8. Both things to be scared of when you're on your own

The ACCIDENTAL ACTORS

We sit down for a chat with actors Anasuya Sengupta and Ahilya Bamroo to discuss their unique journeys to the silver screen

Words by Radhika Iyengar
Photos by Chandni Gajria



Ahilya Bamroo

Anasuya Sengupta

On a warm summer morning in Bandra, Mumbai, actors Anasuya Sengupta and Ahilya Bamroo meet for the first time, settling into an easy conversation about their lives, the surprising turns their careers have taken and the unexpected parallels that now connect them. Though they come from distinct creative worlds—Sengupta a seasoned set designer, Bamroo a digital creator and performer—both have recently stepped into the spotlight as cinema actors, leading viewers to sit up and take notice.

At the centre of this moment is 38-year-old Sengupta, who made history as the first Indian to win the Best Actress award in the Un Certain Regard section at the 2024 Cannes Film Festival, for her raw and haunting portrayal of Renuka in The Shameless—a sex worker navigating the gritty underbelly of Indian society. Though the recognition may seem sudden, Sengupta is no newcomer to the film industry. She spent over 15 years working behind-the-scenes as a production designer—quietly shaping the visual language of films. But the role of Renuka marked a refreshing pivot, not just in her career, but in the perception of her potential—establishing her as a bold, uncompromising talent in contemporary cinema.

By contrast, 25-year-old Ahilya Bamroo represents a different kind of breakthrough—one shaped by the digital age. With a fast-growing Instagram following and a reputation for clever, comic content, Bamroo has charmed audiences with her playful impersonations, multilingual

skits and pitch-perfect accents. Raised in Auroville, Tamil Nadu, in a deeply multicultural environment, she speaks French, English, Bengali, and Hindi—a linguistic dexterity that forms the backbone of her online presence. Her transition from digital creator to debut film actor came in I Want to Talk, where she played Reya, daughter of a divorced, broken man (portrayed by Abhishek Bachchan), who is undergoing multiple surgeries for his cancer treatment. Bamroo’s performance introduced her to a new audience and showcased her depth—hinting at the range of a young artist just beginning to explore her narrative prowess.

Ahilya: How did *The Shameless* come to you?

Anasuya: This is a fun story. *The Shameless*’ director, Konstantin [Bojanov] and I had been Facebook friends for a while, though we had never met – but we have a few common independent filmmaker friends. So he was a name I was kind of familiar with because I’m also an illustrator and I used to post a lot of my work on Facebook. Konstantin always liked and encouraged my art. To be honest, that was the extent of our engagement. And then, slightly before the pandemic, sometime in 2019 if I’m not mistaken, he sent a message out of nowhere, potentially offering me a lead part in his film.

Ahilya: Oh, wow!

Anasuya: When I read the message, I remember feeling so taken aback that I didn’t reply to him for a couple of days. Then obviously, I tried to tell him that this was absolutely foolish, since I didn’t have a body of work. I didn’t even have head shots at the time. I told him that he wasn’t going to get any funding, since I was an unknown name, and that his producers won’t be on board with this. Somehow, however, he convinced

me to read the script... and once I read it, there was no second guessing it. I just knew this was something special.

Ahilya: Just to clarify though—had Konstantin seen any of your acting before or did he just take a blind bet on you?

Anasuya: Actually, he had been trying to make this film for more than 10 years, and was just not able to get the right funding for it. At one point, he had almost given up, and thought that there was no way he could make this film, especially in India. So, he began assessing the possibility of making an animation film for adults with this story. At which point, our common friends directed him to me and my artwork. They felt that I made interesting art, and could perhaps make the animation film with Konstantin. However, the French producers completely shut down the idea of an animation film.

Anasuya: Okay.

Anasuya: Around this time, a casting agency in Bombay was auditioning for the lead role for *The Shameless*, though Konstantin wasn’t really feeling it. That’s when he messaged me saying, ‘This might sound absolutely crazy but I’m getting ready for my next feature film. Would you be interested?’

Ahilya: And the rest was history, as they say. That’s incredible!

Anasuya: Thank you! I realised that you have a similar journey, don’t you? You were also approached to do your first film through social media—Instagram?

Ahilya: Yes! You know, when I was younger and wanted to be an actor, I thought I didn’t have the grit to move to Bombay from Auroville—where I currently live. I didn’t think I could go and be in a room with other girls who were just like me, with equal talent, equal dreams, and then get rejected again

and again. I felt that I was too sensitive and I would break. So I thought, I’m not going to do it. That led me to start making these fun skits and posting them online.

Anasuya: Let’s talk about that for a moment because I’ve seen your content. You’re incredibly talented. It’s like you’re jumping in and out of different skins, doing different accents, different impressions...

Ahilya: A big part of why I’m interested in doing impressions of people is because I grew up in a small, multicultural community in Auroville, populated by very kooky characters—like the strange French librarian or the weird old Russian farmer. They were all these people that one personally knew. And because I’ve always liked acting, I began imitating them around my friends. So it became kind of a thing. Then I realised that maybe I have a knack for being able to do accents. At the time, there were not too many people in India who were doing international accents online and the concept of reels was not huge. In fact, it was just being launched in India.

Anasuya: So, how did you transition from a content creator to an actor in *I Want to Talk*?

Ahilya: It was around this time that casting agents had started to look towards reels to find talent—it was like the modern version of spotting someone at the gas station. It just so happened that a casting director was casting for an international project. They saw a video of mine and then left a message in my inbox, asking me if I would like to audition for a role. And I recall sitting in my tiny room—the one I’ve grown up in; where I make all of my videos; where I had been through every heartbreak—wondering how my work had reached across the world? It was crazy. So, I went to London to audition for the part, but I didn’t end up getting it. However, through that experience, an international agency signed me on, and about a year later, I got the part in *I Want to Talk*.

**“What if I never
get to act again?
This is my only
chance”**

Anasuya Sengupta



Anasuya: That's wild. It's such a good time to have all of this aligned for you. I remember moving from Calcutta to Bombay many moons ago, wanting to be an actor but ended up working behind-the-scenes for several years. We didn't have social media back then. And 15 years on, I decided I had had enough of the city and the hustle of the industry, and moved to Goa to slow down a little bit. That's when I started illustrating because I was looking for different ways other than my set designing career to express myself.

Ahilya: And then, out-of-the-blue, Renuka's character came into your life. What drew you to her?

Anasuya: Honestly, I went into reading the script with a bit of a reservation because I didn't want the story to be an outsider's gaze about the 'poor' Indian sex-working community. When I read it though, it was clear that it was a story of a survivor—a woman on the run. It checked so many boxes. To me, Renuka is nothing less than a feminist icon but an unlikely feminist icon. She's a sex worker who has been dealt the wrong cards. There are so many Renukas like her, who're leading lives where hardship after hardship is thrown at them. When I read the script, I realised that she's rough, abrasive and angry, and I understood why she's justifiably so. Having said that, I also found a tenderness and vulnerability to her.

Ahilya: How did you physically and mentally prepare to embody a person whose life was so different from the one you lead?

Anasuya: You know, I'm not a trained actor. As a set designer though, I've had the opportunity of observing many fantastic actors over the years. I didn't know it then but I was probably taking mental notes. When I got Renuka's role, I geeked out. There was a very physical side of her—because she's a woman who has been on the run pretty much her whole life. In fact, when we meet her in the film, she's literally on the

run—she's moving through buses and trucks, from city to city. Renuka is essentially a lone wolf who has never been loved; who doesn't have anyone. So, I had to really isolate myself to meet her there. Which meant that I spent a lot of time alone.

Also, Konstantin gave me absolute freedom in the way I wanted her to look. I felt that Renuka is someone who doesn't eat three square meals; rather she snorts crack and smack all day. The latter is also such a political thing because drugs are put out on the streets by someone, and then it's the lowest rung of society that takes to it and is later criminalised for it. I wanted Renuka to look extremely gaunt, but at the same time, very powerful and strong. So, I would run two to three kilometres a day for months. I watched documentaries and films, including *Monster*, where Charlize Theron portrayed Aileen Wuornos, a sex worker who turned into a serial killer. There's also a lot of material on sex workers in India.

For me, I went into this thinking, 'What if I never get to act again? This is my only chance', and I became obsessed with it. I started making script notes, which evolved into writing about Renuka's personality, her childhood, her past—I kind of wrote her into existence. It helped me solidify who she was so much, that when I was walking into a scene, I knew exactly at which point in her life she was, what her trigger points were, and why she was behaving a particular way.

But what about you, Ahilya? Where did you draw inspiration from for your character Reya in *I Want To Talk*?

Ahilya: In many ways, my character was quite similar to myself... In the sense that she was a kid who grew up with divorced parents. My parents were not together when I was growing up either. But Reya is not somehow the child—she's the parent who is parenting. In the movie, when her father is ill, there's this caretaking-caregiving aspect that Reya

has to do, which isn't something I had to do in real life. But in terms of prep, at that particular point in my life, there were a lot of themes of fatherhood coming to the forefront for me. Someone extremely close to me had lost their father, and I was very involved in the grieving process of this person. Then, my own father and I began spending more time together after a couple of years of not speaking that much. *I Want to Talk* is one big ode to fatherhood. Overall, emotionally, it was quite easy to get into that mind space. And the crew was extremely down-to-earth. I felt so comfortable around everyone. The team was small and intimate. And of course, the director, Shoojit Sircar...

Anasuya: He's amazing, isn't he? I'd love to work with him.

Ahilya: He's also an incredible person. You feel super safe knowing that this film is in the hands of somebody who is sensitive, caring and empathic. It was a dream to be able to do this film as my first.

Anasuya: I'm curious, when you create content, how much of you is in the reels that you make, and how easy is it for you to transition from reel-making into acting for a film?

Ahilya: Actually, I do this quite intentionally. I make a video where I can just show up as myself—where there is no prep needed for me other than to simply just turn on the camera. I made it this way so that whoever I am when I wake up, is my persona online. Of course, slowly over time, I've realised that I want to look slighter nicer, but I try my best to remain as authentic as possible. Of course, when I'm playing a character, then I'm playing that person. In terms of a transition, for me it wasn't that tough. I feel that when there is a known actor who is acting, the viewers have a clear understanding that he/she/they are playing a part in a film or an ad. But when it comes to digital creators who've become public figures primarily by showing a part

of their lives to their viewers, there exists a parasocial relationship between the followers and you. It's where they feel that they personally 'know' you, so it becomes tougher for them to disassociate that online version of yourself (the identity you have moulded as a digital creator) with the identity of an actor. For instance, I did an ad for an energy drink and it was a lovely ad in my opinion. But someone reached out and wrote, "I love you, but how could you do an ad?" And it felt strange, since this is my job. A girl's got to eat.

Anasuya: I agree and completely get it.

Ahilya: Thanks. I was wondering, what are your thoughts on international cinema? In the sense that you've worked in Indian and international films. What do you think Indian cinema can incorporate from foreign films and vice-versa?

Anasuya: I think Indian cinema needs to be more open in terms of diversity—different kind of faces and a different way of seeing things. If you think about *The Shameless*, it's a Bulgarian director making a Hindi film, without knowing a word of Hindi. Moreover, all our technicians were European. Co-production is, in fact, amazing because you're blurring the borders a little bit. That being said, what's interesting about European cinema is that there's big diversity in how people look. While growing up, I was often told I was 'attractive'—a word that felt more like an evaluation than a compliment. No one called me 'pretty' or 'beautiful'.

Ahilya: Because you didn't fall into the very conventional requirements of being an actress, including being 'light-skinned'?

Anasuya: Exactly. That's how most girls are still raised in our country and it's exhausting. I don't care about it now at 38, but when I first came to Bombay to act, I was 21-years-old and it did affect me. Such things just defeat you.

“Someone reached out and wrote, ‘I love you but how could you do an ad?’ And it felt strange, since this is my job. A girl's got to eat.”

Ahilya Bamroo

Ahilya: And the industry keeps reminding you that you must look a certain way. It doesn't matter if you can act well or not...

Anasuya: It never stops. Like, you'll see as you get older, Ahilya—that there is a youth-obsessed notion in the industry, especially when it comes to women. The system will have you believe that if you are 35, you're essentially dead.

Ahilya: And the only roles you'll be offered are of mothers...

Anasuya: Exactly. So, the pressure of looking a certain way...is also there in Europe—one hundred percent. In fact, it's everywhere in the world and I think that's painfully boring. But I still find European cinema to be more diverse. At the end of the day, it's also not just about learning from each other. It should be about joining hands and working together. I think we'd be more enriched as a film industry and would be able to tell better stories. *ralph*

TRIPLE TRIPLE TRIPLE THREAT

How to be a presenter with Harriet Rose

Words by Josh Jones
Photos by Stephanie Sian Smith



Radio, TV, live red carpets... Harriet Rose can present on them all. Cutting her teeth on iconic UK radio station KISS FM (where she still presents two regular shows), she's also a mainstay of UK TV, hosting the The Masked Singer spin off show The After

Mask, backstage at the MTV Europe Awards, red carpets at The Brit Awards, and interviewing the biggest stars in the world. To continue the Ralph How To series, we figured there was no one better to give us the inside scoop on how to be a presenter...

I've read that you often go very quiet just before you go on air. What's the last thing that goes through your mind before you're on camera?

That only really happens for massive things, and usually when it's things that I've never done before. Like when I did the Brit Awards' red carpet recently. My mind will literally go blank – it's a total wipe out, and I'm just rehearsing what's gonna happen in my head. What I do, and I think this is a really good tip for anyone that gets nervous about anything is imagine how I'm going to feel afterwards. That's all I do, over and over and over again. I've got a blank mind but all I'm doing is imagining, for example, walking off stage and smiling. It genuinely works! I remember doing a DJ set once, and it wasn't going well, but it was really important – a big, big DJ set in front of some incredibly important people. But it wasn't going the way I wanted, so I dipped behind the decks and I just imagined everybody enjoying themselves. Doing that relaxed me so much that I smashed it – it was one of the best sets I've done ever. That technique has never not worked for me!

As a presenter, do you have an amazing ability to eavesdrop at parties while someone's talking to you, because you're so used to a producer yelling in your ear?

Do you know what? Yes, I'm amazing at listening to multiple things at once and looking like I'm listening to everything. I think that isn't something I've learned, I think that's why I'm good at my job. I have ADHD and I remember at school, I went up to a teacher, and telling them my brain is going fast and the world's going really slow. And no one understood at the time what that was so I spent my whole school life with everyone being like, "Oh, she's just mental". Now I've learned to utilise it in a way that benefits me with my career, because when an interview, for example, isn't going the way I want it to, I'm already 10 steps ahead of it, changing the vibe.

That's a big skill in interviewing,

which sets up the next question nicely... you famously had a 'date' with Jason Momoa for an interview, where you had to think on your feet quickly.

Was it the time when I said, "I'm a lesbian, and you're promoting a film?"

That's the one. He rolled with it, and then you headed in a whole new direction with the interview.

That's my favourite thing in the world. That's why I love interviewing people like Jason, because he is so self-confident and not scared of learning and being in a new environment. We were in this igloo thing and when I got in it I said, "this is like a date" and from there I planned to say I was a lesbian. There's no way to tell if he's going to take that well. It's about making that judgement in the moment. Is he thinking this is funny? And if he is, let's go. It's just about listening to the other person, and not just with your ears, but with your eyes. If someone's body language is telling you a different story to what they're saying with their words, you know what to do. It's nice to be a 'seasoned interviewer' now, where, even if someone is awful, which rarely happens, or are really anxious or nervous, you never really get perturbed by that. Because whatever happens, happens.

Even in today's world, an interviewer saying they're a lesbian to a massive Hollywood star is kind of rare. I know you are very public about wanting to be a beacon for lesbian interviewers in this mainly straight world.

I do it all the time. I've gone viral for it before. I was interviewing Ewan McGregor and Hayden Christianson for one of the Star Wars films. Hayden plays Anakin Skywalker, who of course becomes Darth Vader, and I said to them, "When I was a kid, I had a crush on Darth Vader, but now I'm a lesbian, so nothing makes any sense." And it was their reactions that went viral, because it was really funny. They both just went, "Huhhhh..?" because it was such a random thing. But I love doing that: subverting the norm of what we



talk about. Because the amount of times that a presenter might mention their boyfriend and no one blinks about it. For me, if I can bring up being a lesbian in normal scenarios, then that's making it so normalised that you don't notice. It's like my tag line now.

Do you use researchers now?

I do have researchers now, but I've always done everything myself – I'm very much a control freak when it comes to preparing for things like that. However, there are some incredible producers at KISS FM who I work with on a regular basis who are a-ma-zing. There's a girl called Jade, who I write a lot of my interviews with. She did the Jason Momoa interviews with me. She is extremely encouraging, and is the kind of person I can go back and forth with when we're writing it together. If I don't agree with her, I feel able to say no. What happens is, someone will write a skeleton of what they want to achieve from the interview, and I'll take that and roll it in a completely different coat – and then we put it out.

I feel like a lot of people don't realise how much work presenters put into to scripting their interviews.

Absolutely. And also the interview will end up totally different to what anyone wants – everyone knows that when they hire me. I do love collaborating with other people, because I think, while it's good to have control and your own ideas, I always have a better idea when I bounce it off someone else and vice versa. I think when you can bounce something off someone else, they can give you an alternate perspective, especially if they come from a different background to you, different sex, different gender, different sexuality. You can get more out of someone if you have that.

How do you adjust your mindset for presenting on both radio and TV? Dead air is traditionally 'the worst' thing in the world in radio, but in interviews, you're meant to give people that space to talk.

Good question! My first big job in the world

of media was KISS Breakfast with the boys Jordan [Banjo] and Perri [Kiely], and people often ask me how I don't swear on air or edit myself. Because I'm so many different versions of myself it's like I've got different people I can click into. With Harriet Radio, there's no way I can swear because I've turned off that section of my brain. Also, when you're presenting on the radio, time is so much slower. So 30 seconds feels like four minutes – I could go to the loo and come back during a 30 second ad break... and I have. What I actually had to learn was to slow down for radio because I speak so fast in normal life. Because you're not speaking to an actual person all the time, you have to learn to pace yourself. Also, sometimes it's really fun to leave things silent and let the bed drop – which means the sound you hear underneath the talking – just let it fall away, make your point and boom! Back into the radio. It's really fun to play with audio in that way. But I would say, I think the most about what I am saying when I'm on the radio.

Do you ever think about the listeners and the viewers when you're presenting?

Yeah, all the time. I think it was Terry Wogan who said: "I'm talking to you. I'm not talking to we or them or they." It's one person I'm talking to, even if you're sat in a group of people listening to the radio, I'm talking to just you. And he said that the key to radio is focusing on talking to that one person, and making it be me and you. I think about my audiences in every single link with every single thing I say. I also think about myself and what I want to bring to it. I have, my own KISSTORY show, which is me on my own, and then I do the breakfast show with the boys, which is more silly and fun. For my my own, show, I'm talking to people at the weekend who may be working, because that show is from 9am till midday. So a lot of the time it will be people in their vans and cars, working. So it's my job to make their day a bit better. My aim is to slightly improve their mood in those 10 to 15 seconds between the songs. So I'm constantly thinking about what they

might be doing, what they might be thinking, you know, depending on the weather, depending on what the vibe is in the nation.

Quick fire one here: shag, marry, kill: radio, TV, red carpet.

Ooooh! Kill radio, marry TV, shag that red carpet. I'm old school in the sense that my dream was always telly. I love radio so much, and I want it in my life for the rest of my life, but I thrive on a red carpet. That's something that thrills me and gives me an energy. I remember I did the EMAS, and Lewis Capaldi and Stormzy weren't doing press, but they both walked past and said hi to me. Then they both stopped and spoke to me together. That kind of stuff, it's not because I'm amazing and better than everyone else. It's because I have been in this industry for a long time, and people know who I am now.

If you ever got a chat show, who would be on your dream sofa?

I really want to interview Adele. I really would like to go light and shade with her and have fun, but also have a deep conversation. I'm desperate to speak to Rihanna, because I adore her. I think her business acumen is one of the most impressive things I've ever seen. Do you know what she is? She is a likeable billionaire. She is someone where you want to fund their lifestyle, and pay for their kids tuition. I'd love to talk to her about that. And then, honestly, it would probably be an old-school legend, someone like Judi Dench. Before Tina Turner passed away, it would have been her – I love Tina Turner, but Judi Dench is someone I would love, or Maggie Smith, if she hadn't sadly passed away, like an old school legend in the game, who has got some stories to tell. Or one of the old gay men in Hollywood would be cool as well. *ralph*

HARRIET ROSE'S TOP 5 TIPS FOR PRESENTING

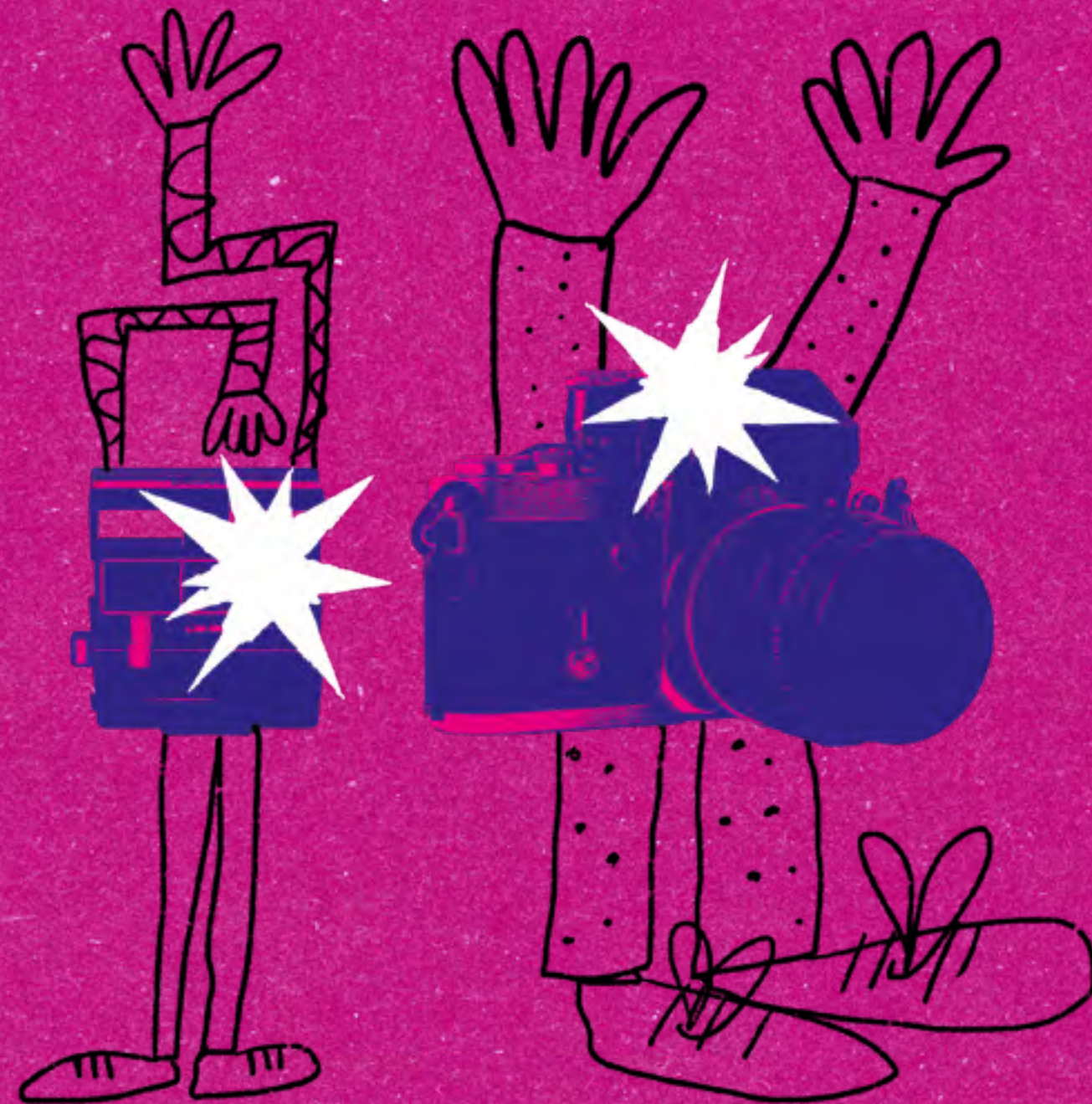
1. Stop talking and listen.
2. If something goes wrong, don't panic. It's going to make the interview more interesting, even if it's really bad. Because a lot of people go viral for bad things, and then get loads of jobs from it... not that that's ever happened to me! The bad things are the good things, and they make great anecdotes for interviews.
3. Enjoy interviewing everyone, not just your favourite people.
4. Vibe check. Imagine you're DJing and if no one's dancing, stop playing that music and change your tune. I once did an interview with Keanu Reeves, and he's such a serious guy. He's a really introverted, really lovely man. But I was being silly sausages, and it wasn't his thing. So I switched up the interview, and we had such an amazing chat. That's the skill, you've got to go with the vibe of the situation.
5. Be curious. You are there to get more out of them than an answer to a question. If you're not curious, and if you let your fear take hold, you're never gonna win with an interview.





Words by Josh Jones
Illustration by James-Lee Duffy

CHASING



An insider's look at chasing the most famous singer alive

BRITNEY

As well as being one of America's best hip-hop journalists, Jeff Weiss has written an incredible quasi-autobiographical account of life as a gossip mag paparazzi. Waiting For Britney Spears is an incredible book, filled with car chases, LA at it's best and worst, a constant competition to get a Britney Spears headline scoop, and Von Dutch trucker hats. It doesn't let up one second as we career through the 2000s quite literally at breakneck speed.

Most importantly Jeff... how many Von Dutch hats have you owned?

I have never owned a single hat in my adult life, let alone a Von Dutch. When trucker hats were initially in vogue, I considered them a harbinger of the suffocating irony that eventually infected the millennial sensibility and led to the concept of 'cool' being euthanised sometime around 2021 (or whenever Gen Z snuffed out the torch by making the internet streamer an aspirational ideal).

It's true that several people have looked iconic in Von Dutch hats, but no one has ever managed to avoid looking like a sponsored ad in one. Christian Audigier, a designer of midlife crisis club-wear, acquired the brand's license and ensured Von Dutch's ubiquity. And the best thing that I can say about his taste is that he's lucky to have escaped criminal proceedings in the Hague related to his central role in the Ed Hardy pandemic of 2007.

While I have immense sympathy for the follicly-challenged, the truth is that my hair is too luxurious and wavy to be confined into a polyester and nylon prison. But you should still buy the limited-edition *Waiting For Britney Spears* trucker hat, because writers should not be role models.

This book feels like you just sat down and wrote till it was done. What's the story behind the writing?

Did you do that?

Depending on your chosen sundial, this book either took two decades, eight years, or fifteen months to complete. It was scrawled in a redwood forest at the top of Big Sur and in an off-season ski resort near Lake Tahoe, which I was forced to flee due to encroaching wildfire. I thrashed in an ice-encrusted cabin in Lake Arrowhead and amidst the pan-searing heat of the Palm Springs summer. It taunted me at a rented Air BnB in CDMX, and in my apartment at the vanishing point of Sunset Blvd. Writing is a magic trick and the idea of ease is merely an illusion. As Paul Valéry said: "books are never finished; they're abandoned."

"Writing is a magic trick and the idea of ease is merely an illusion. As Paul Valéry said: 'books are never finished; they're abandoned'"

When did you decide to write the book?

The title *Waiting For Britney Spears* came to me long before Britney's most harrowing tribulations – let alone the conservatorship, or even when she finally regained her freedom. Initially, it was both a literal

description of my tabloid purgatory, and a symbolic green light at the end of the dock. The American Dream instantiated, the promise revealed, the possibilities unlocked. It's complex trying to obliterate America's sweetheart.

Were you actually one of those entertainment journalists, Jeff?

It depends on how you define 'entertainment.' Let's just say that I have lived through enough 100mph car chases to have never had the desire to see a single *Fast & Furious* film.

You're massively well-known for being one of the best hip-hop journalists in the world. Why did you decide to write about one of the poppiest artists in the poppiest times?

Because I lived my raps. And because if you're going to tell the story of the morphine drip death of the American dream, you need to go straight to its most vivid manifestation.

How did you tap into the spirit of you as the main protagonist?

I'm unsure if the unnamed narrator is actually the main protagonist. He's more like the tour guide through a cursed blunt cruise through Los Angeles' most corroded arteries.

Your Englishisms for 'Oliver' the paparazzi character with dubious morals are on point. Was there anyone who influenced this?

I have to give full credit to the infamous Mel Bouzad, the true paparazzi extraordinaire who showed me grace and generosity in a treasonous world. Those are his real photos on the cover of the book, and we recently did the audiobook together because otherwise, no one could ever do his Cockney accent justice.

What's worse - the paparazzi nightmare of the '00s or social media hellscape of today?

The most damning criticism that I could give

to the contemporary social media Tophet is that it makes the stalkerazzi era of the '00s seem almost quaint in contrast. I have zero nostalgia for the times that I wrote about, but I do credit the post-reality age for making it appear almost charming.

What are your thoughts on celebrity rights to privacy?

I think that Justin Bieber's "money money money money" rant was one of the greatest bits of cultural criticism of the last 22 months.

Who are worse? US or UK paparazzi?

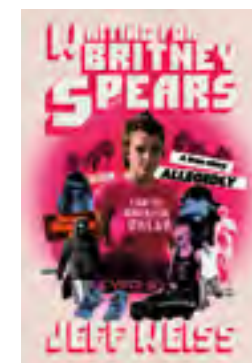
They're equally nefarious, but you have to respect the originals. And there's something about American greed that makes it seem even more venomous.

Have you sent Britney a copy of the book?

I don't have her address, but Oliver/Mel insists that I should put a copy on her windshield.

What's the best Britney song and why?

'Piece of Me' – it foregrounds the paparazzi, lawsuits, and fixation about her image. The ravenous desire for attention, sex, and controversy are all embedded into the music. You can practically see the face of the 'American Dream since I was 17' projected on a million screens, small and large, pre-figuring a millennium where, whether you know it or not, you are always consenting to be filmed. And I also think it's kind of funny that its producers, Bloodshy & Avant, are quietly the guys behind Miike Snow. *ralph*



*Jeff's book
Waiting For
Britney Spears
is out now on
MCD/FSG*

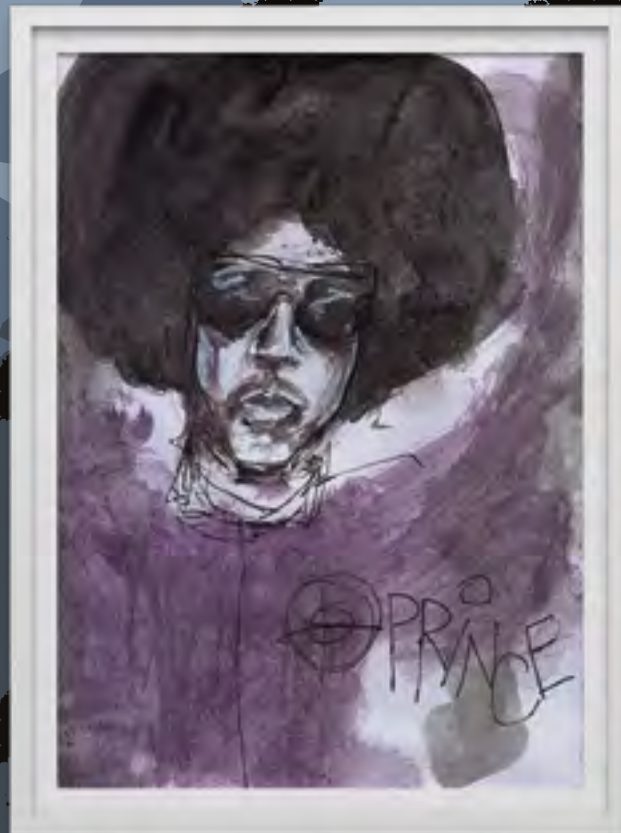
CHUCK D'S FAVOURITE PAINTINGS

Chuck D has always been an artist. Not just the legendary frontman of Public Enemy and acclaimed hip-hop icon, he was a political cartoonist at university and no matter whether he's making music, drawing, painting or writing his "Naphic Grovels", he's always wanted to excite, shock and amaze. So we asked him the story behind his favourite paintings.





Cypress Hill: currently the greatest rap group. Led by B Real and Sen Dog, their consistency and commitment is unparalleled.



Prince: The fact that he considered things I did as influential is mind-blowing. My recording with him, 1 to 1, at Paisley Park was an unforgettable day.



Harry Belafonte: MR B – to know him personally and to get his inspiration, 1 to 1, was something I reiterated in my latest Naphic Grovel *INTERFICIAL ARTELLIGENCE: The Moments That Met Me*. I presented this same piece to Mr B.



Public Enemy: Myself and Flav with one of the world's GOAT DJs, DJ LORD – who did a solid 21 years of Public Enemy duty 1999-2020. Besides four years of Prophets Of Rage he is part of the fearsome foursome of Cypress Hill.



Woody Guthrie: Power in words is what I tried to infuse in rap. The fact I received a Woody Guthrie Award reconfirms why I do what I do.



NY Knicks Uniforms: I draw all the time as therapy. I design uniforms for sports teams for recreation.



Ice Cube: The Creative Super Genius. In Everything Audio Visual. People overlook he's the Rapper MC that took the focus off New York hip-hop.

Chuck D's new solo album Radio Armageddon is out now on Def Jam

Jamali Wants To Be

Silly

The coolest comedian on the circuit, Jamali Maddix, talks stand-up, making documentaries and how he doesn't let death threats get to him.

Words by Alexandra Haddow
Photos by Rebecca Zephyr Thomas

I don't really get intimidated by many people. That's not me squaring up to fight your dad, it's just that I talk to people, on stage, for a living, so it comes with the territory. I'm scared of hairdressers, but who isn't? (I'd rather die than tell them it's not quite what I asked for). But on my way to interview Jamali Maddix, I'm nervous. He's a brilliant comedian, a daring documentary maker, a host on Never Mind the Buzzcocks, and he came fourth on the eleventh series of Taskmaster. Frankie Boyle loves him, so he's hot shit. The man has range. He's interviewed neo-Nazis for Vice in Hate Thy Neighbour, something I tried to avoid asking him about too much because "everyone does", and he's pretty sick of talking about the fact that an infected tattoo caused him to drop out of university, giving him the time to give stand up a go. He feels like the sort of guy where, whatever he says, you're going to agree with him. He just feels like he probably knows more about everything than you do. Plus, he looks like he doesn't care what anyone else thinks. I met up with him at London's Mama Shelter to see if my preconceptions were true...

Alex: When I say who I'm interviewing for *Ralph*, it's either women who say "Oh I love them!" or it's guys saying they're fans. This time everyone said, "Jamali's so fucking cool." Do you think your fans are cool?

Jamali: (laughing) It's varied! My audience has spread now.

Alex: In what way have they changed?

Jamali: Yeah, my fan base has changed. My boy had to remind me the other day, I was on tour and I'm like, "Yo, my fans are getting

older!" And he was like, "No, they're just the same age as you." And it's like, oh shit, yeah, I'm not 25 anymore. I think one good thing is I think my fans have kind of grown with me. I'm turning 34, and I kind of don't want only 20-year-olds coming. Even if I go and do a university gig sometimes, I don't actually know what to talk to them about. If I do a gig and it's bare young people, there's a hard-to-relate level to it. I get quite a spread now, but I still get the young guys and girls with neck and face tattoos though.

Alex: Was that a thing for a while?

Jamali: Yeah. That was like most of the crowd, everyone had neck tattoos. So I still got them, I get all the guys with the nice trainers, and Hypebeast guys. And now I'm getting older people – I'm getting a lot of older couples. I had a couple in Cambridge and they were in their 60s and they flew from Switzerland to come watch the show.

Alex: I feel like the more range your audience has the more of a compliment it is.

Jamali: I think when you're younger and you first start getting your base of people, you care more about who they are and you kind of go, "oh yeah, cool." Because you think it's a reflection of your identity. So you want cool, young crowds. But as you get older in the game, you kind of want people that want to listen to what you've got to say, and find something they relate to, and find what you're saying interesting.

Alex: Do you think you have a spread politically? I always feel like you're a really political person without being overt about it. Do you know what I mean?

Jamali: Yeah, I get what you're saying.

Alex: Then when I was recapping loads of clips of yours and I realised you don't actually explicitly talk about politics that much.



Jamali: No, I think the most political show I did was *Hate Thy Neighbour*. But even that, I don't see that as political, because I'm just saying "Nazis are shit." Do you know what I'm saying? (I do, they are) I'm basically a communist now for saying that, I suppose. [laughing] I think I spent the beginning part of my career trying to be right. And I think I'm trying to spend this part of my career trying to be honest. Sometimes being honest isn't about being right.

Alex: That's interesting.

Jamali: Yeah. 'Cause sometimes there's some thoughts I have where maybe it's wrong, but I just feel it.

Alex: I guess we all do.

Jamali: I think when you're honest, even if someone doesn't agree with your idea, whether it be left-wing, right-wing, or whatever, they can appreciate that it's what I honestly think. People can resonate with an honest opinion as opposed to the 'right' thing to say.

Alex: Definitely. You strike me as someone so laid back that you probably accidentally became brilliant at comedy?

Jamali: Not really actually! When I was a kid, all I wanted to do was be funny for money. I used to watch Jim Carrey, and I used to think you had to be a comedic actor. I didn't really know what stand-up was, or I thought stand-up was only an American thing. My aunties used to have pirate DVDs of black American comics, like Bruce Bruce, and Def Comedy Jam, and all of those DVDs. I'd watch them religiously. On repeat. I was always interested in the idea of being a comedic actor. I was never really a great actor though. Then I saw one of those *100 Greatest Comedians* on Channel 4, and I remember I saw Bill Hicks on that. I thought Bill Hicks was great, but he's very much what a 14-year-old boy would think of as the coolest shit ever. Smoking on stage, talking about the

government man! I flunked out of school. I was sort of fucking around. Then when I was about like 16 or 17, I tried to do stand-up. I had a friend called Ayo at the time. He said, "Come to this open mic, and just come watch." And I'm there, I think his girlfriend was on. And he said, "Oh, by the way, I've put your name down." It was Lion's Den in King's Cross.

Alex: So have you never had a muggle job?

Jamali: I've had three proper jobs. I was a paintball referee. I sold double glazing on the phone, and I did labouring with my dad, and he fired me after three shifts. I was just broke, living at my mum's house, and living off student loans for a course I was never going to.

Alex: I can't imagine doing a job now that I don't care about.

Jamali: Exactly – I can't remember who said it, but another comic said one of the things about the luxuries of being an artist is time.

Alex: Oh, hugely.

Jamali: I was moaning to my mate about my schedule the other day and he said, "Yeah, but, you know... if you want to go go-karting on a Wednesday afternoon, literally, this is the price you pay." You know what I'm saying? If you want that lifestyle when everyone is at work, but you sometimes have to gig on your birthday, that's the trade off.

Alex: You're obviously known for your documentaries as well as your comedy. Was that something that you've pursued because you wanted it or did somebody come to you and say, "We think you'd be great for this"?

Jamali: I had an idea for a show. The first show I did was *Hate Thy Neighbour*. I worked with *Vice*, and that show came around. The original idea was called *Wacky Racists*.

Alex: I wish they'd gone with that title.





Jamali: Yeah! I wanted to go around and interview racist people and then give them a rating. So, I'd be like, "Ah, he only gets three swastikas," – it's just ridiculous. And mix it with stand-up, but then they said, "Well, let's clean up a little bit and have it a bit more of a thing". And then that's what *Hate Thy Neighbour* became. I never really saw myself as a filmmaker, or a documentary guy or anything. I still kind of don't. But I guess I've done like, maybe 30 films now?

Alex: I hate to tell you, but you are a filmmaker.

Jamali: [laughing] Yeah, it's just, I was always kind of a curious guy. I was the guy where if you're in a pub and there's a guy who's a bit of a nutter there, I always want to talk to him. Because I grew up in London, we kind of live on top of each other, so you're pretty tolerant of everyone, you have to be. You kind of have to interact.

Alex: My boyfriend is from Holloway, in north London, and he's like that. I don't suffer fools very well and he's always so chilled with people.

Jamali: The thing is man, it's your neighbours. I sort of grew up with mad people and people with weird views or weird lives and stuff. So it never shocked me, you know what I mean? Where I was growing up was like a weird area where you had quite a bit of affluence and then poverty and it was this weird mix. Some aspects of it was quite religiously conservative, but then also five seconds down the road there was a red light district.

Alex: I'm jealous, as someone from a shit town where there's nothing to do.

Jamali: But in those towns you have a lot of time to think. Whereas London we have a lot, it's constantly going. So there's not really a lot of time to sit back and actually process. You sort of just exist more. Where I feel like, people that grew up in those little

towns, they have a thoughtful nature about themselves. They've got to think about stuff.

Alex: It's a brilliant analysis. I feel like we spent a lot of time daydreaming about leaving the town. We romanticise London. You were saying that you didn't feel like an actor but actually you've done quite a lot of acting roles.

Jamali: Yeah, but again I act as myself. Like even for Michelle De Swarte's show *Spent*, she calls me up and says, "Oh I wrote the part with you in mind." And even when I got there she had the script but she said "Yeah but just say what you think the character says."

Alex: Was it improvised?

Jamali: Yeah, we improvised a lot. I mean I've known her for quite a few years. We've always got along and I think the obvious thing was to write us as cousins. I did have to learn to read out a Hebrew passage as my character though and let me tell you, you cannot improvise that, that is a hard language to pronounce if you're not used to it. I enjoyed it though.

Alex: You've gigged internationally a lot, do you do that to challenge yourself?

Jamali: Yeah, it makes me try to write from a place of being human, more than my exact environment. That's how I came up! I'd go and do all these mad gigs abroad. All those international bookers are mental. There's this one guy in Belgium who makes you stay in his mum's house. You heard about this guy? He makes you stay in the loft.

Alex: No! I'm scared about the phrase "Makes you."

Jamali: Yeah! You won't book your hotel. He'll tell you he's got you a B&B and you get there and it's his mum's house. And then you stay in the attic. Then we went to the

French Riviera with him and someone had to sleep in the kitchen. It was just madness.

Alex: You've done such a broad range of things, including *Taskmaster*, which is quite a diversion from your early projects, and you were described as "the most chaotic contestant" they'd ever had. Did you enjoy it?

Jamali: I'm happy I did *Taskmaster* because I had done all these nasty documentaries and after all that stuff I was just burned out. I wanted something fun. Something that was just pure silliness. I just wanted to be silly for a bit. I think you can become a bit too *strokes his beard thoughtfully* you know?

Alex: I do know (Can the editor get me a beard for this please?) [On it - Ed.]

Jamali: I'd become a little bit too serious. Even my comedy was just getting a bit too serious. And then *Taskmaster* came along and I was like, "Fuck yeah, I'll do that."

Alex: What's something you want to do that you haven't done yet in your career?

Jamali: I don't know man. I've never done a special.

Alex: That's surprising.

Jamali: Yeah, I get that a lot. I just never did one. I sort of made this thing with myself recently. A little while ago I said when it comes to this, a lot of this is for sale. You want me to go here and talk to this person now? All right. You want me to sit here and talk about music or talk about something? Fine. But when it comes to stand-up, I'm quite protective of it.

Alex: Has a death threat from any extremist ever bothered you?

Jamali: No. I'm just going to say no. (And he says he's not cool) Because they're always quite cartoonish. It's never really based in reality. It's always just like some guy from Kentucky. You kind of go, "Well, I live in

London, mate. You're going to fly all the way over here and you've got a gun? You're not going to do that."

Alex: (laughing, impressed)

Jamali: The reality is, look man, all of my whereabouts are on my website. And they're very affordable tickets. It would have happened by now. It is only going to cost you £22 to kill me.

Alex: Is there any part of you with the rise of, you know, full-on fascism in the West and all over the world that makes you think, "I was in on the ground floor of this. And I could see this coming?"

Jamali: It's weird. When I first started making the show, the first episode we did was Sweden, and it was with rather young fascists and people. And they were saying words and stuff that we didn't even know what it meant, like "Alt right." Which I guess just wasn't in the human consciousness. Because those things existed on 4chan and 8chan. When I started the doc, Trump had announced he's running. And it went from the beginning of making the film and him being a joke candidate. Then when I got to the end of making the films, he'd been elected to run for the Republican Party. And then for the second series, he was in power. So I was there for that whole part of America. I was there at the inauguration, I was, you know, sort of involved in those things.

Alex: What you're saying is, you've caused this.

Jamali: Yeah, they were like "This guy's going to come in a DeLorean." So we don't have to live through this. I wasn't a doomsayer. But some of the things they were saying, the extreme people, the extreme fascists and the Nazis, some of the stuff they were saying on a micro level, I would hear it every day from your conservative uncle.

Alex: Yeah. (Sorry to my own uncle here)

Jamali: You know what I'm saying? Let's do another silly show... Why the fuck not? *ralph*



DISCO 2025

Oliver Keens heads to the dancefloor to answer the question, “what even is disco today?”

Words by Oliver Keens

I remember the moment I realised that ultra-camp disco music had stopped being the exclusive domain of ultra-camp gay men.

It was 2015, and I was DJing in a once trendy, in-the-know London neighbourhood that subsequently became a destination for big groups on a big night out. A quite lairy and laddy young guy holding a pint of beer started walking up to the booth, leaving his male-only coterie of early-twenties pals on the dancefloor. 'What's he going to ask me to play,' I thought to myself: 'a garage anthem, some face-melting house banger, maybe something even harder like drum 'n' bass perhaps?' His request was so sensitive, so feminine, so camp, it shocked me. "Mate, are you going to play 'Love Sensation' by Loleatta Holloway anytime soon?"

It wasn't always the case that young men were fans of the frequently fabulous genre of disco. When I was that age, in the mid-90s, grunge and Britpop occupied the mostly straight male critical sphere. The music press at the time treated the word 'disco' as a byword for flimsy, cheap and tacky. Sure, the rave explosion of that decade famously introduced Brits to the complimentary delights of ecstasy and dance music, which often sampled old disco tracks. 1990's rave anthem 'Ride on Time' by Black Box sampled the aforementioned Loleatta Holloway track, for example.

But there was a lingering irony to it all: most British men could handle disco if it was packaged as hard, pounding music to gurn to. But there was still something forbidden about the softer, more feminine sound of pure disco.

As a bisexual man in the city in the '90s, the only places I'd hear disco music was in London's gay bars, which at the time were rarely frequented by as many straight people as today. Bars would commonly try and ostracise themselves from any straight clientele by showing gay porn videos on multitudinous screens. One of the only songs

of that era to ever truly evoke the spirit and swirl of original disco was by two iconic gay men: the Pet Shop Boys, on 1999's 'New York City Boy'.

But then, around 10 years ago, a slow shift began to happen to the most fizzy and upbeat of genres: people started to finally take it seriously.

Having been hitherto cult artists, modern disco acts began to make albums that were critically lauded. Singers such as Roisin Murphy and disco band Crazy P started to have their modern take on disco music critically lauded, as did later-converts like Jessie Ware. In clubland, the shift was even more pronounced. Having opened in 2004 as an almost solitary outpost for the genre, weekly Vauxhall gay club Horse Meat Disco started getting noticed by the mainstream – chiefly via an unlikely weekly show for grime radio station Rinse FM. To one of the four residents at the club, James Hillard, the modern appeal of disco is simple: "Things are a bit shit today and young people especially need a form of escapism. Disco is the ultimate sound of liberation and escapism."

Two British DJs, Artwork and Skream, who had hitherto been pioneers of the very intense, head-nodding and often rather gloomy sound of dubstep, suddenly pivoted to playing disco sets. Other DJs known for frenzied house and techno sets began doing the same, such as Jackmaster and Chicago house legend Derrick Carter, who started playing his excellent *Derrick Does Disco* sets globally. But while the sounds were technically of the '70s, the sonics were often pumped beyond all recognition. DJs playing 'disco' around this time would in fact be playing remastered edits that significantly augmented the records with fat beats and embellished baselines that would provide the punch of their trademark sounds. It was disco, but jacked to the eyeballs on steroids.

On the one hand, the style of music which middle America literally burnt as part of

“Disco is the ultimate sound of liberation and escapism”

*James Hillard,
Horse Meat Disco*

the racist and homophobic 'Disco Sucks' movement of the late '70s has finally become acceptable. But it's also subject to an identity crisis. What we might hear in a 'disco set' on a 2025 dancefloor is not the same as what our parents' conception of disco was at all. What exactly is disco today?

Defining this is tricky – not least because the word itself appears in a myriad of misleading places. You don't need to listen to Chic before a 'disco nap', nor do you need to dance to Sylvester after taking a 'disco biscuit'. The band Panic at the Disco! made no disco music, while the song 'Disco 2000' is similarly not disco. Within two miles of my house in east London is a vegetable shop called 'Disco-Licious' and I still kick myself that I never hired a moped through a now closed rental service called, ingeniously, 'Disco Moves'.

The use and abuse of the word 'disco' comes from the fact that, more than any other genre, disco is a vibe. It's an attitude, a fashion sense and a certified good time rolled into one. But who best encapsulates that depends very much on your age and era. To an older generation, no living human is more disco than Grace Jones. At 76, the grand dame of disco still performs constantly on the festival circuit with the zeal and *joie de vivre* of a twenty-something, hula-hooping the entirety of her perennial set closer, 'Slave to the Rhythm'. It's not just on stage that she wears her disco credentials – interviewing her a few years ago, she told me that whenever she's in a club "I have to party by myself... Dancing is the most important thing for me," she told me. "I usually tell people: don't try and talk to me, let me dance! I've always been like this. I used to go to Tramps in London and I'd just tell the DJ what to play, and dance."

Yet, while middle-aged folk like me are able to see still-touring OGs of the disco-era like Grace Jones, Sister Sledge and Chic's Nile Rodgers, it's possible we're looking in the wrong place for 2025's definitive disco queen.

To Bea, a close friend's teenage daughter, the ultimate disco icon of our era is Dua Lipa. Despite growing up in a household with disco loving parents, it wasn't until the singer's *Future Nostalgia* album of 2020 that she felt an affinity with the genre. "The whole album just felt like it was much more alive and fun than the records my parents listened to, I think because Dua is such a charismatic singer and presence. I could relate to it a million times more than the older stuff," she told me. For her, Doja Cat's 'Say So' (an omnipresent soundtrack to a million TikTok dance videos a few years ago) and Sabrina Carpenter's 'Espresso' fall under the category of disco just as much as Gwen Guthrie or Diana Ross.

While a generational divide over what counts as disco might exist in the ether, there are some places where a strict definition is required, in fact, it's essential. Take the racks of a prestige record shop, for example. How do they decide what makes the disco section and what doesn't? Jamie Upton has worked for London's most enduring second-hand record chain – Music and Video Exchange – for nearly 30 years. The shop has such a high turnover of second-hand plastic that the question of what is disco and what isn't is an almost hourly preponderance.

"First of all, if it's danceable black music made up until 1980-ish and on a 12-inch, it's probably going into the disco section," explains Upton. "To further complicate matters we have a SONY (Sound of New York) section. This is for the post-disco sound of labels like Prelude and West End, but also records from that scene, such as those made by The Clash or Yoko Ono. Anything on a Loft-type list [referencing the music played by David Mancuso at his seminal early-'70s Loft parties] would go in there, even if it's classic disco."

But would Dua Lipa go in? Or Kylie Minogue, or a 12" copy of Mark Ronson's modern disco floorfiller 'Uptown Funk'? "Good question," reckons Upton, "They're not not disco, but I

think as well as being a sound, disco was also a moment in time – before house became the dominant form of up-tempo black music. So a punk record from 1980 can be a disco record, but a ‘disco’ record from 2025 can’t be. Unfair, perhaps, but I don’t make the rules,” he jokes. “When I started here, my colleague Sean P would always put Deee-lite’s ‘Groove Is In The Heart’ in there, which I always found odd. But now I agree with him – it’s the last glorious hurrah of disco before all was consumed by house.”

While physical records are subject to debate about how they’re labelled, the same process is often crudely applied to DJs too. Grace George is one half of powerhouse DJ duo Raw Silk – a pair of London-based women who have become a beloved and almost omnipresent feature at the city’s best clubs for a decade.

Despite having started their careers playing decent amounts of silky disco, they long since pivoted away from the sound to concentrate on championing new music instead. “To do a really good disco set,” says George, “you have to be dedicated to the cause – and that means being comfortable with playing more or less the same music most nights, because there aren’t going to be many new ‘70s and ‘80s disco records coming out any time soon.” Yet, as is frequently pointed out by female DJs across many genres, there’s a tendency for the industry to still bill them as disco DJs – solely by virtue of being female. “People assume that if you look a certain way, that you’re a woman who plays disco. Women generally get judged online for their appearance far more than men, and often get pigeonholed into being labelled as a disco DJ in the process.”

A way to boil down the often thorny discussion of what – or indeed who – is disco might be to reframe it as a battle between mainstream and the underground. Our shifting conception of disco is, at heart, a simple war for narrative supremacy and legacy between two NYC clubs that both

opened in 1977: Studio 54 and Paradise Garage. For most of my life, the former was the most eminent club in disco history, mostly down to the gossip, scandal and sheer no-knickers decadence. Yet while Studio 54, situated in a former opera house, was an insanely storied place, its musical policy lacked any real legend that might survive through the ages. The music was fun but essentially just commercial disco, chosen primarily to keep the clubs’ many celebrity guests happy, and not threatened or challenged.

By contrast, the music at Paradise Garage – the underground LGBT club housed in a former garage – was selected by a maverick so exacting and perfectionist he would sometimes stop the party for an hour at a time, erect a ladder on the dancefloor and manually clean the club’s six disco balls if they weren’t gleaming enough. That man was Larry Levan, and his incredible skills as a DJ – both technically and also in terms of his varied and maverick selections – have provided disco with a modern hero who has acted as a talisman for all that we find so invigorating about disco today.

The heroic queer legacy of the Paradise Garage would have stayed largely exclusive to its devoted dancers who patronised the club until its closing in 1987 – were it not for one seminal book covering the breadth of dance music history. First published in 1999, *Last Night a DJ Saved My Life* by Frank Broughton and Bill Brewster has slowly and quietly changed the way the world thinks about music. Specifically disco, a genre that LCD Soundsystem’s James Murphy even states he was unenthused over until he read Broughton and Brewster’s book. The book does a lot to relay the madcap genius of Larry Levan – who died in 1992 – and in doing so, it created a true disco hero for our age.

Brewster, an in-demand DJ in his own right, as well as a true scholar of the dance, is keen to stress how few people in literature regarded disco in a positive fashion. “We

“Disco has done so much to take the sting out of modern men, encouraging them to be fun, and dance with each other in ways their dads never did.”

were the first people to write about disco in a non-derogatory way. One of the things we wanted to do with disco was defend it – by saying it’s been hugely influential and correct the long-held idea that it was all crap.”

Brewster is rightly proud of the book’s impact, but acknowledges that its romanticism of the era of vinyl-only disco has created some modern quirks. Take the modern fetish for vinyl and audiophile sound equipment, to the point where even Richard Branson has opened a high-end listening bar in his latest London venture, Virgin Hotel Shoreditch. Surely we can safely lay much of the blame at Brewster and Broughton’s door? “We created a monster,” admits Brewster, who ironically has no regrets about selling his vinyl collection (comprising two full vans’ worth) a few years ago. “It irritates me, as if it somehow sounds... better.”

With disco having become slightly gentrified today, and some records changing hands for

over £200 on second-hand vinyl website Discogs, played in slightly earnest and moneyed ‘listening bars’, it’s possible to feel like all this has been a step too far. The fact that underground legends like Larry Levan have become as totemic a disco presence as ABBA is an amazing achievement, as is the fact that beered-up lads request Loleatta Holloway tracks now. Disco has done so much to soften and take the sting out of modern men, encouraging them to be fun, dance with each other in ways their dads never did and – well – act a bit like gay men, frankly. But as James Hillard from Horse Meat Disco is keen to point out also: “It’s the enduring musicality and sophistication of disco that has seen it endure for so long. That’s important to remember. Amidst all this intellectualising, we should never forget that disco is still just that undefinable, indiscernible thing at heart: a vibe.” *ralph*

GRUFF RHYS' WELSH WINNERS

Not long after we asked Welsh troubadour Gruff Rhys for a playlist using songs only from his fatherland, the great Welsh poet, singer, actor, film maker and mentor Geraint Jarman passed away. So, in his memory, Gruff dedicated this entire playlist to songs by Geraint, all sung in their mother tongue.

Geraint Jarman

Neb yn Deilwng

Geraint Jarman

Seren Wîb

Geraint Jarman

Ty'd Draw Heno

Geraint Jarman

Gobaith Mawr y Ganrif

Geraint Jarman

Lleisiau Gwallgofrwydd

Geraint Jarman

y Dyn Oedd Yn Hoffi Pornograffi

Geraint Jarman

Ambiwllans

Geraint Jarman

Lle Mae'r Bobl wylt yn Byw

9. Geraint Jarman

Crïo'r Nos

Geraint Jarman

Dim Lle i Droï



Gruff Rhys *American Interior* re-issue
out now via Rough Trade Records



SCAN TO LISTEN

BATTLE JACKETS LONDON

Meet Louis Noguera, the DIY artist connecting metalheads and punk masses across the globe, one patch at a time, through his Battle Jackets London project.

Words by Tracy Kawalik
Photos by Chris Bethell



Under a blood-red moon, a leather-clad crowd congregates at a Camden heavy metal haunt. But tonight, they're not here to howl at the lunar eclipse, or attend ritualistic gatherings like Satanic Recovery (sessions for sinners looking to get sober). Instead, they've gathered for a Battle Jackets London meet-up to compare their customised creations, purchase rare patches to emblazon empty spaces, swap techniques and... stitch.

The origins of battle jacket making aren't easy to pin down. After the Second World War, ex-US airmen-turned-bikers decorated their flight jackets with pin-up girls, cartoon characters, and bomb decals to mark each successful mission.

As motorcycle clubs gained traction across the US, outlaws recontextualised the practice, using cut-off jackets to flex club affiliation, geographic territory, and individual role and rank — propelling the patchwork style to Japan's Bosozoku biker gangs and notorious British hellraisers like the Rockers and Ton-up Boys. In outlaw biker gangs, a greater number of club-related patches, known as 'colors', represents a higher rank, whereas non-outlaw motorcycle clubs often feature just a single large back patch.

Motorcycle jackets became synonymous with rebellion and as a result were adopted by feverish youth movements like skinheads, punks and metalheads — who not only pushed the personalisation of their battle jackets into bolder territory with band patches and political messages, but also transformed battle jackets into musical armour: a medium for expressing identity and creative dexterity.

By the 1970s, methods evolved to include hand embroidery, with fans recreating band logos in the absence of commercially available patches. Battle jackets were adorned with studs, rivets, and chains, while punks popularised hand-painted artwork and

slogans. As demand grew, bands smartened up and began producing their own patches, which quickly became cult collectibles — proof of attendance and mementos of iconic gigs and tours. Many of these are now highly sought after by collectors and can be worth hundreds of pounds.

Nu metal and grunge sparked a shift in style and expression during the 1990s that might have killed off customisation but within subcultures like black metal, thrash, and death metal, battle jackets persisted as an integral part of the culture. Post-millennium, as the popularity of earlier metal styles resurged, battle jacket-making has had a full-blown renaissance.

Fast forward to 2025, and trailblazing battle jacket designer, metal obsessive, and DIY artist Louis Noguera is connecting metalheads and punks across the globe.

When we meet at Sixty Sixty Sounds guitar shop on London's iconic Denmark Street, he's unveiling his coveted collection of battle jackets one by one from a suitcase — face hidden behind long espresso-coloured locks, aptly flanked by 200 guitars hung floor-to-ceiling, ranging from a customised leopard-print Les Paul to a rare '70s double neck SG.

"I got into metal when I was about 12 or 13 years old," Louis says. "My parents signed me up for guitar lessons one summer, and when the instructor asked me during the first session what I wanted to learn, I literally couldn't name a single song that had guitar in it. So I went home, and my dad made me a playlist of metal classics— and from that moment on, it very much became my personality."

Louis Noguera's passion for 'patch work' was first piqued when he saw Metallica play at the Sonisphere Festival and spotted lead guitarist James Hetfield's battle jacket. "It was the coolest thing I'd ever seen, and I knew instantly: I have to make one of these,"



Louis explains – his friend’s mum sewing the patches onto his first-ever battle jacket. “It hit me that there definitely had to be more people out there who were in the same position I was in. My mum encouraged me to start making them. So I bought loads of jackets from [high street store] River Island that were on sale and stocked up on patches.”

Louis honed his stitching skills while creating his Battle Jacket London fan account on Instagram — and soon after started landing commissions. “People would DM me asking for a battle jacket with specific bands,” he says. “So I’d go pick up another one from River Island and make it. I still remember sewing my first jacket to this day — it had a Slipknot back patch that I sent to Scotland.”

When it comes to parting with jackets that boast seamless personalisation and days worth of craftsmanship, Louis has a zen state of mind: “The jackets are important to me because for a long time I didn’t really have ‘my thing’, I wasn’t really obsessed with anything, then I found the battle jackets and I just really enjoyed making them. Picking what patches I wanted. Discovering what makes a bad one and what makes a good patch. Designing them. Laying out the look. The whole process is very personal. Each jacket is going to be unique, you will never have the same as someone else.”

As I glimpse through Louis’ private collection I find hand-painted artwork, clever layering of T-shirt logos behind glitter-etched patches, coloured stitching, and decorative duplicates of favourite metal bands like Mastodon and Municipal Waste. I ask him if some of the customised creations hold more emotional value, such as his girlfriend’s battle jacket or even his father’s, which Louis has brought along to the shoot. “Some jackets mean more to me than others,” he admits. “I’m very picky and a perfectionist when it comes to patches. I add things and change them all the time. The jacket that I wear all

the time, that’s my OG jacket, there are a lot patches I wouldn’t want on it now, but because I’ve had that jacket for so long it’s always going to be the one that means the most to me. I’d feel super weird if someone else wore one of my personal jackets — I really only like to wear them myself.”

Today, Battle Jackets London has become a platform for metalheads and punks to connect both in the Big Smoke and across the globe. As I write this, Louis has just hosted a competition at Camden’s subterranean rock dive and iconic live music joint, The Underworld, attracting over 250 battle jacket aficionados who came to check out the 40 competitors and buy patches from a range of collectors. “Back when I was 15, I had a little more time on my hands,” he says. “Now I’m working on about ten different things I’ve stepped back from making them as much as I used too. But over the years I’ve had the privilege of making them for some pretty cool people,” he proudly beams. “I did two for Nuclear Blast Records and I’m making one for Metal Hammer at the minute. I’ve done one for Norwegian heavy metal band Kvelertak and Municipal Waste. I did one for American metalcore band 36 Crazyfists. People follow me like Gary Holt, the lead singer of Exodus, Slayer, and Max Cavalera who co-founded Sepultura.”

Alongside collecting patches, Louis has just launched the Battle Jackets London podcast and is in the process of editing a Metallica documentary about their fans. “It’s about people who we met over two years following the band on tour, who all have really deep stories. We’ve gone to their houses, or went to their place of work, and done a deep dive into what connects the fans.”

Touring with bands has shown Louis just how far Battle Jackets London’s reach has grown — from backstage encounters to market stalls, he’s regularly recognised by fans across the globe. Back home on London soil, he’s keen to unite his growing fanbase at Battle



“My proudest accomplishment with Battle Jackets London is bringing people together”

Jacket London meet-ups where he teaches aspiring makers how to sew patches, and lends his expert eye on placement.

What’s the holy grail of patches in his sprawling collection, I wonder. “The coolest patch I’ve ever purchased is my *Death Spiritual Healing* back patch,” Louis reveals. “It’s a vintage 1990 back patch for one of my favourite ever death metal albums, and it’s super rare. You rarely see them outside of the US and when you do, they’re normally hundreds and hundreds of quid. I saw a guy wearing one at a festival in America, many years ago and I’ve had my eBay notifications switched on ever since! I finally found one about a month ago and bit the bullet. I still haven’t decided where to put it, whether I wear it on a jacket or frame it!”

Louis’ eyes dance with fire when he talks about metal, and his love for his craft is just as infectious. “My proudest accomplishment with Battle Jackets London is bringing people together. I’m especially proud of the

recent competition at The Underworld — seeing that kind of turnout from people who share my passion, at an iconic metal venue I’ve been going to since I was a kid, was so cool. It’s also exciting to be planning events later this year with places like Black City Records in Bristol and Dark Earth Records in Merseyside.”

“I’m quite a socially awkward person; I wasn’t always good at going out and talking to people. So I keep an eye out at my events for people like me and link them up with other people to work with on their own jackets or sit down with them if they need help. I didn’t have any friends who were into metal when I was at school and now I’ve managed to meet some really cool mates through this, I get recognised and chat to people all over the world,” Louis waxes poetic as he packs up his collection. “I want the Battle Jacket community to keep growing in London and everyone to meet like-minded mates at my meet-ups.” *ralph*



A full-page photograph of Tim Heidecker in a room with warm, orange-toned lighting. He is wearing a patterned jacket and jeans, leaning forward with a serious expression. In the background, a woman is visible, partially obscured by a large, stylized white text overlay.

MAKING SCENTS

Tim Heidecker and Marta Pozzan
star in the indie film of the year

Words by Gemma Lacey
Photos by Shervin Iainez

As David Lynch once said, “it’s a strange world — and one where the absurd is absolutely possible”. Case in point: our cover stars Tim Heidecker and Marta Pozzan were brought together in a twist of fate involving a first-time film director, an obscure yet utterly charming plot, and an intoxicating perfume. Throw in cameos by Julia Fox, Kevin Kline, and Gina Gershon, and you’ve captured our attention.

Fior di Latte, written and directed by Charlotte Ercoli, pairs multi-hyphenate Heidecker with actress and ingénue Pozzan as an unlikely couple entwined by scent, memory, and desire. Heidecker plays Mark, a creatively blocked playwright who stumbles on an unexpected portal back to his happier self: huffing perfume to conjure vivid memories of an Italian summer long gone. What begins as wistful nostalgia quickly devolves into fragrant obsession, as Mark loses himself in reverie and detaches from the world around him. His descent draws him into the orbit of an eccentric perfumer — played with musical whimsy by Kevin Kline. As Mark becomes more intoxicated by the past, he’s forced to reckon with what he’s escaping from: creative failure, romantic disconnection, and a deep yearning to relive what can no longer be touched.

Ercoli’s directorial debut is a dreamy, offbeat comedy-drama that drips with surrealist flourishes and indie soul. Heidecker delivers one of his most layered performances to date, marrying his signature deadpan with a quiet emotional unraveling. Pozzan brings a grounded warmth to the role of the woman pulled into his aromatic orbit, while Kline’s turn as the Willy Wonka of fragrance is nothing short of delightful. *Fior di Latte* is a

visually lush meditation on memory, identity, and the fine line between inspiration and delusion.

The result is a film that’s as strange as it is seductive — a fragrant escape into the beautifully absurd.

Someone who’s no stranger to absurdism is Tim Heidecker. Never one to chase mass appeal, for the better part of two decades he’s built a career around the off-kilter, the chaotic, and the deeply uncool—from the cultish Adult Swim’s *Tim and Eric Awesome Show, Great Job!* to the surrealist spiral of *On Cinema*, his long-running film review satire series. But what makes Heidecker fascinating isn’t just his cult status—it’s the unexpected tenderness that keeps creeping into his work. Whether through his side career as a singer-songwriter or his indie film performances, Heidecker seems increasingly drawn to characters whose absurdity masks a kind of aching vulnerability. “I think I’ve always gravitated to playing guys who are a little lost,” he tells me. “They’re reaching for something, even if they don’t really know what it is. That’s where the humour lives—and also the sadness.”

In this movie, we see him tackle what might be his most complex role of his career. Heidecker plays Mark, a deluded American artist attempting to reinvent himself in Florence. It’s a role steeped in contradiction: arrogant yet fragile, self-assured yet spiralling. Paired opposite Marta Pozzan—who also co-produced the film—Heidecker’s Mark is a man both completely in control and utterly unmoored. “I have a history of playing unlikable characters,” he says with a smirk. “Mark fits right in. But I think there’s something slightly sweet about him, too. He’s pathetic in a way that you can almost root for... almost.”

The same can’t be said for Francesca, the character played with deadpan brilliance by Pozzan. Where Mark fumbles, Francesca

Styling: Erik Ziemba Make-up: Bex Marie Hair: Rachel Lita PA: Sean Linezo





character played with deadpan brilliance by Pozzan. Where Mark fumbles, Francesca evolves. Over the course of the film, she shifts from wide-eyed curiosity to quiet revolt. It's a transformation that feels deeply personal to Pozzan—who, like Francesca, came to Los Angeles from Europe in search of something bigger.

Fior di Latte began not with a script, but with a direct message. Pozzan reached out to Ercoli on Instagram after seeing her short film *Little Jerry* and suggested they work together. The two hit it off creatively and emotionally, bonding over shared experiences as expats, artists, and women navigating a still male-dominated industry. "I'd never had anyone write something for me before," Pozzan says. "And suddenly there was a script with a character who felt like a younger version of me. It felt like someone had seen me, really seen me." Within four months, Pozzan had helped raise the money to shoot the film. "I didn't think it would actually happen," she admits. "Even actors with major names struggle to get indie films made. But we did it. We willed it into existence."

Heidecker came onboard via a mutual connection—Ercoli's partner, filmmaker Owen Kline. "I read the script and kept seeing my character's name over and over," Heidecker recalls. "It was clearly his story. And I thought, well, this could be terrible... or it could be great." He reached out to Ercoli, liked what he heard, and committed to three weeks of filming in New York and Florence. "I tend to say yes to projects where the risk feels exciting."

Despite their vastly different career paths, Heidecker and Pozzan had immediate on-screen chemistry. They first met in LA, rehearsing scenes at his house while her dogs played in the background. "His calm grounded me," Pozzan says. "It was my first lead role in a feature, and I was terrified. But Tim never made me feel like I didn't belong.

He was generous, funny, and totally present." "I had one big question going into this," Heidecker says. "Why would a woman like Francesca be interested in a guy like Mark? So I made him funny. Slightly charming. There needed to be just enough spark to believe she might give him a chance—before realising he's a walking cautionary tale."

Shot on location in Florence and Brooklyn, *Fior di Latte* is part romantic fable, part emotional horror story. Its aesthetic borrows from vaudeville and vintage Italian surrealism, with flourishes that recall early Lynch and Jodorowsky. "It's candy-coloured, uncomfortable, and kind of beautiful," Heidecker says.

But the sets weren't always so enchanting. Much of the New York portion was shot in a New York apartment dressed as a hoarder's dream of clutter, dust, and lived-in chaos. "It was a scene," Pozzan laughs. "But that's what made it so real. I'm not Francesca—I'm very clean, very styled. But I've known girls who live like that. I've been that girl, once or twice." For Heidecker, the discomfort was part of the draw. "I've done big-budget sets with trailers and endless waiting around. I actually prefer this kind of environment—chaotic, cramped. It feels more alive."

Still, some days pushed them to the edge. "We were doing scenes surrounded by rotten food, no AC, people tripping over gear," Pozzan says. "It was a lot. But it bonded us." Adding to the unlikely magic of *Fior di Latte* is the wider cast. Julia Fox appears in a supporting role that echoes her own tabloid-saturated persona but strips it down to something rawer. Kevin Kline—yes, that Kevin Kline—also makes a late appearance, lending the film a gravitas that belies its tiny budget. "Getting Kevin was wild," Heidecker says. "He's one of my heroes. The fact that he showed up, gave a brilliant performance, and treated it like any other film—no ego, no distance—that was surreal."

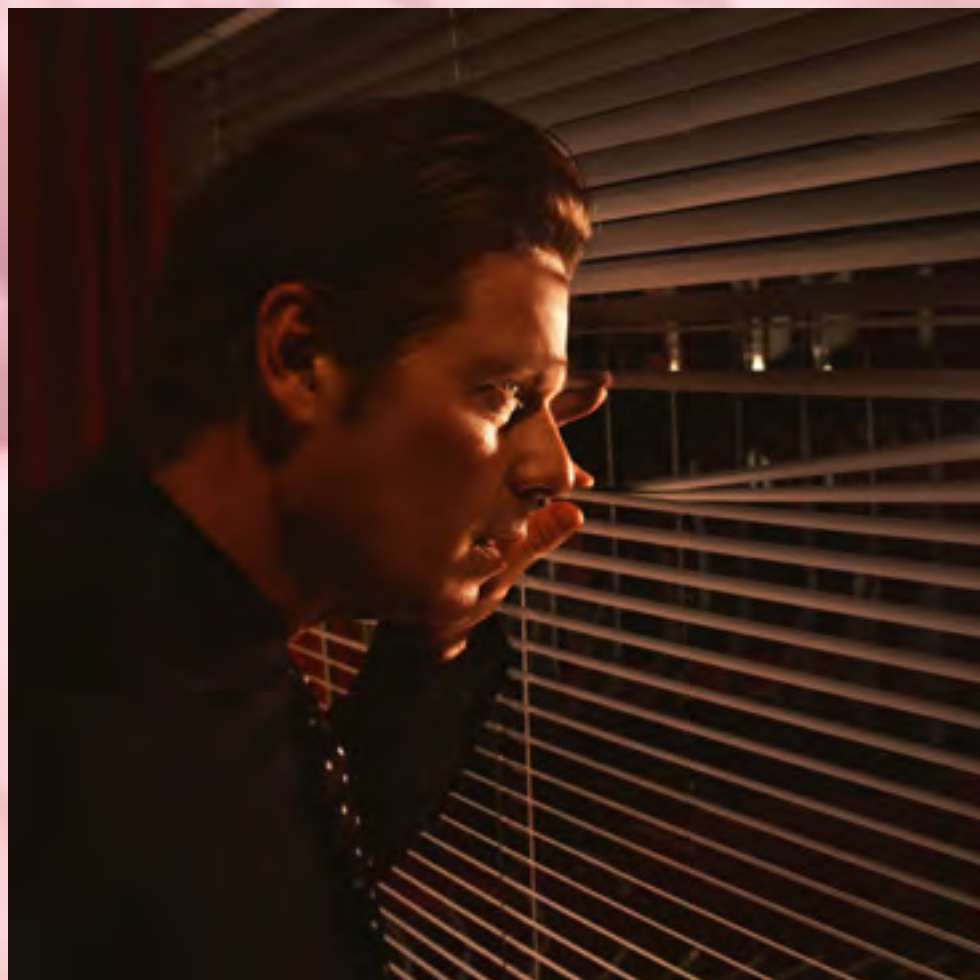
**“I’ve stopped
waiting for
permission.
I make the stuff
I want to make”**

Tim Heidecker

**“This wasn’t just
a film. It was an
exorcism. It was a
goodbye to the girl
I used to be”**

Marta Pozzan







Fox, too, was a coup. “I pushed hard for her,” Pozzan says. “She brought something unexpected. A kind of feral energy that cracked the whole thing open.”

While *Fior di Latte* is fictional, Francesca’s story pulls heavily from Pozzan’s life. Born in a small town near Venice, she moved to Milan as a teen, then to London for university before finally landing in LA. She started as a ghostwriter for *Vanity Fair Italia* before pivoting to modelling and later creative direction. “I never saw myself as a traditional actor,” she says. “But I’ve always loved storytelling. Whether I’m behind the camera, in front of it, or writing the thing—I just want to tell stories about complex, flawed women.”

After years of playing glamorous roles in commercials and cable dramas, *Fior di Latte* was her first chance to step into a character with depth. “Francesca makes bad choices. She’s vulnerable. She’s also ambitious, angry, and quietly brave. I knew her. I was her.” Since wrapping *Fior di Latte*, Pozzan has begun co-writing her next film, a semi-autobiographical feature about being a young Italian woman navigating power, love, and ambition in Los Angeles. “It’s dark, funny, and very real,” she says. “I’m working with Zach Shields, who writes for Alma Har’el. He’s helping me find the structure without losing the weirdness.” She’s also begun pitching to direct her first short film and starts work in July on movie *The Dregs* – a comedy thriller, featuring *Baby Reindeer*’s Nava Mau.

For Heidecker, too, the evolution continues. He’s still making music (his 2022 album *High School* received rave reviews) and recording new episodes of *Office Hours*, which he runs via subscription service, Patreon. He co-founded his own streaming platform, HEI Network, to give web series/podcast *On Cinema* full independence and is developing a new series slated for 2025. “I’ve stopped waiting for permission,” he says. “I make the stuff I want to make. If it finds an audience, great. If not, I’m still making it.”

For someone who once sang, “I’m not gonna be on the cover of a magazine”, he’s already been proven wrong or, as he puts it, “I think I just willed it into being by saying that.” With *Fior Di Latte*, there’s a sense of surprise overall that in this day and age an indie like this can still get made but it’s clear this was very much a group effort and that ethos permeates the movie. For him, it’s an instinctual thing: “I’m a pretty collaborative person, so I think it’s very hard to be motivated to do stuff on my own. It’s much more fun and productive to do it with other people, so I try to get myself in those situations as much as possible.”

At its core, *Fior di Latte* is about power—who has it, who gives it away, and who learns to take it back. But it’s also about collaboration, and what happens when people from different worlds come together to tell a story that feels like neither of theirs—and both. “This wasn’t just a film,” Pozzan says. “It was an exorcism. It was a goodbye to the girl I used to be.” For Pozzan, there’s more a sense of determination to make things happen and to carve a niche for herself outside the stereotypical roles she gets offered, “where I play a decent character, a respectable woman that does well with her life, that makes her own choices.” For both actors there’s a sense of allowing the work to breathe, or as Heidecker puts it, “Once it’s done, it’s out there and it’s no longer really yours. So you might as well enjoy the making of things and not worry so much about the results.

As *Fior di Latte* heads to Tribeca, there’s a palpable sense of arrival. Not the kind that comes with blockbuster openings or streaming deals—but the quieter kind, the kind where the people involved know they’ve made something real, on their own terms.

And in an industry obsessed with scale, that may be the most radical act of all. *ralph*

WORKOUT

A trip to Japan's incredible Muscle Girls bar

Words by Hannah Crosbie
Photos by Bella Howard



What's a girl with a teenage anime phase and quarter life crisis to do these days? Go to Japan, next question.

It's a place I have always, always wanted to visit. It's a place I know a lot about (teenage anime phase) and as far away from London as possible (quarter life crisis). It's also a place that many complain is overwhelming and frustrating to navigate.

This, as my friend Rachel says to me on our first day, is utter bullshit. "People just want to have things handed on a plate to them," she says. "It's so easy to get around. People need to work these things out for themselves without reading a travel guide". Right. Where's the discovery? We note that we have, perhaps, already become two old friends who like to complain about the younger generations. Gen Alpha are apparently trying to cancel Charli XCX for doing gak. We tut as we get on the Yamanote line.

Rachel and I have a friendship that has, at the time of writing, endured almost a decade. We were in rooms next to each other in our first year at a horrible Russell Group university, with a horrible collegiate system. We both survived, one of us even got a degree, but this is the first time we've been on holiday together since we've known each other. And it's become obvious to us both very quickly that we holiday in entirely different ways. Rachel is a gloriously type-A traveller: she knows where everything is, what trains to take, how to unwrap tuna onigiri while keeping the seaweed intact. She has packed three pairs of jeans.

I'm type B: I drink lemon sours from 9am, pack unsuitable footwear, which collapses my arches on the second day, and enter the country without knowing for certain if I have an adapter. It's because of Rachel I was able to experience Tokyo in a far broader way than I would ever have on my own – she organises a cherry blossom festival, the Studio Ghibli

museum and the best ramen I've ever had. I was extremely happy to go with the flow, but I had one request. I wanted to visit the Muscle Girls bar, located a five minute walk from Ikebukuro station. I'm not one to follow up on a TikTok recommendation, even if it's in London. I'll send it to a couple friends saying something banal like 'omg we should go here', before apparently making a subconscious mental note to never go there again. But there was something about watching a man get slapped by a dozen extremely cool women that got me interested in a way a gastropub residency just doesn't. Plus, all you can drink for £30 per person is a good deal however you slice it, and watching men get slapped is a welcome bonus.

And so, wearing the novelty hosiery I bought from Shinjuku some hours earlier (it's always nice to make an effort) we set off for Muscle Girls. We meet the manager, Mama-san, outside who ushers us in as everyone takes their seats. He's the only man who works there, his name an ironic nod to the 'mama-sans' – female bar managers that work at traditional host bars.

Within five minutes of us getting there, I have had a protein shot, an enormous pint of lemon sours and am watching a shirtless American get grapefruit juice squeezed on his head by an incredibly short woman whose biceps are as big as my thigh.

It's a chaotic scene: bright pink walls, an enormous communal table-cum-bar, strings of international flags, shouting and cheering, and a far cry from the laid back nature of the traditional host bars. Lots and lots of bashful men. The women drinking are smiling. The women working are loud and funny with an unwavering, unapologetic charm. The Muscle Girls are in control and there are many rules, and that's why it works. It seems like a lawless place by design. No ping-pong of the sports bra straps, no inappropriate touching. Crucially,



“We’re assigned to a woman called Megumi for the evening: she’s wearing gym gear, has a fabulous haircut and perfect teeth. I notice this immediately because she’s always smiling. She’s also absolutely stacked. I ask her for her gym routine to break the ice. “Oh no, this is all from pole dancing.” I’m in disbelief, I cannot overstate how stacked this woman is”





you can't book for larger groups of people, presumably to deter rowdy stag dos.

At the head of the evening, a microphone is passed around by the MC and we're told to give our names and where we're visiting from. There are Americans, Australians, a few Brits and quite a few locals. This is smart. When people are anonymous, they behave badly. When everyone knows your name, there's nowhere to hide.

Now that we're all friends, the fun can start. We're assigned to a woman called Megumi for the evening: she's wearing gym gear, has a fabulous haircut and perfect teeth. I notice this immediately because she's always smiling. She's also absolutely stacked. I ask her for her gym routine to break the ice. "Oh no, this is all from pole dancing." I'm in disbelief, I cannot overstate how stacked this woman is. (Her handle is @megumi_fitness, if you don't believe me). A quick follow on Instagram and I can see she dances competitively and offers private lessons. I know what I'm doing next time I'm in Tokyo.

We ask Megumi if we can buy her a drink, which is standard practice at host bars. Although, there is a rumour that these drinks are sometimes water with artificial colouring, so that the hosts don't get too drunk on the job. Megumi says I can buy her a protein shot, which I dispense into her mouth via a novelty syringe device. Every little bit helps, I guess. After I order my second enormous lemon sour, we are given the Muscle Girl menu. This is a list of experiences we can pay for, on top of the £30 all-you-can-drink deal. While we peruse it, a pale woman wearing full gothic Victorian attire is attempting to do 50 reps on a chest press.

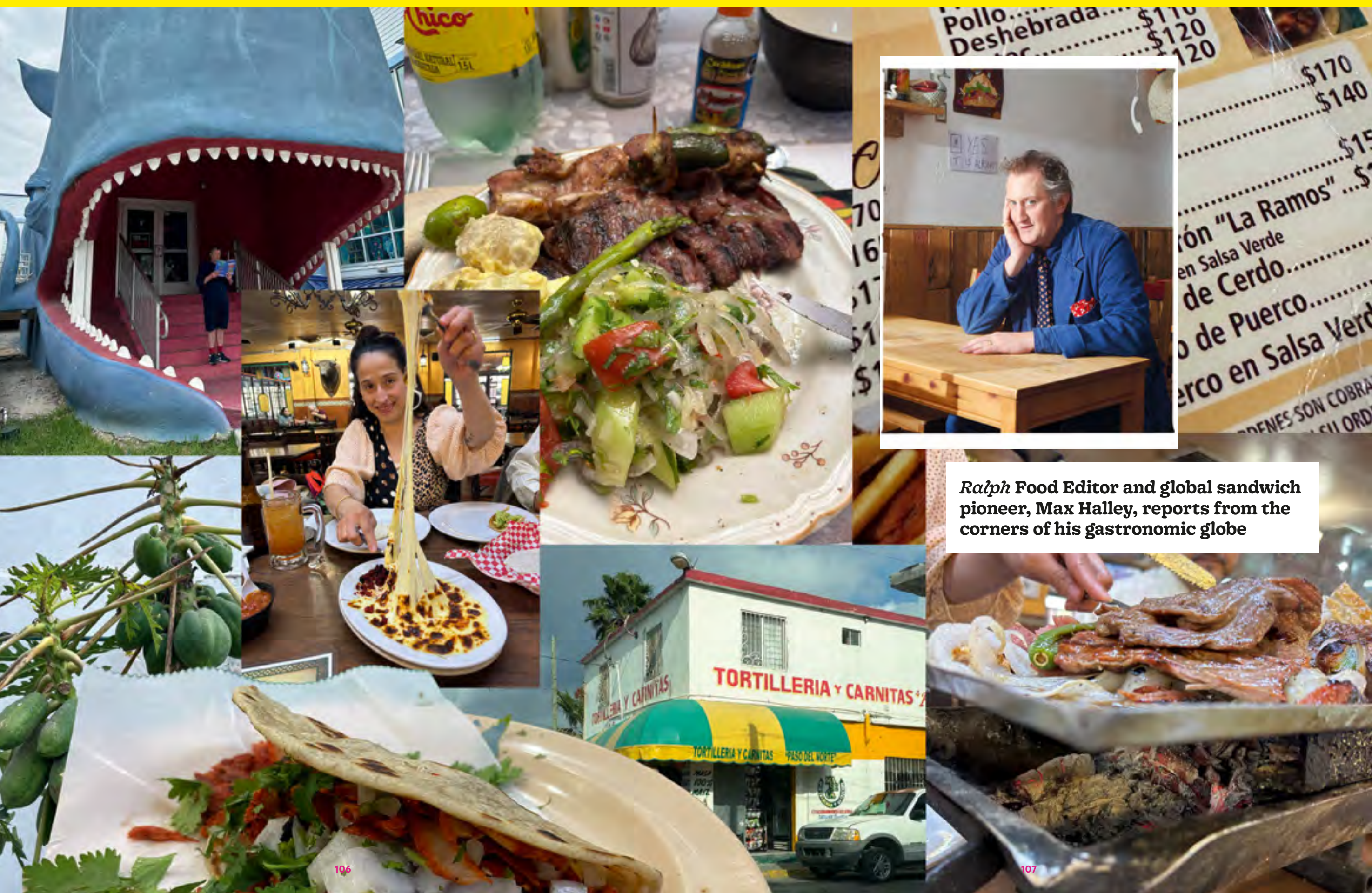
There's getting a photo with your muscle girl, sure, then there are honeymoon carries, piggy back squats, slaps and butt kicks. There are also activities only for girls: push ups, hugs and the intriguingly named 'muscle sandwich'. I didn't need to spend too much

time working out exactly what that is, as when I turned my head, there is a woman beaming ear to ear as two of the muscle girls embraced her from either side.

I ask Megumi what she would recommend as a first-timer. She recommends the 'falling muscle', where she drops from the top of the pole as I lie at the bottom, stopping inches from my face. I scream. Rachel gets a honeymoon lift and says it was the smallest she's ever felt in her life. And then, the 'muscle kick', one of the instances of my life where I wish they hadn't had the idea to put cameras on phones. If you can, for a moment, imagine 12 of the strongest people you've ever seen kick you on the arse (with eye-wateringly varying accuracy), that's exactly what it is like. Externally, joy and laughter. Within, a real fear that my vulva may never look the same again.

My favourite moment, 'the muscle carousel', is spinning round on the pole with Megumi, her legs supporting both our body weights as we scream and twirl around. Now that I'm a few drinks deep, I ask her about her previous work in Tokyo. "Muscle Girls is the safest place I've ever worked," she says as she pours us another drink. "When you pole dance, sometimes places can be really sleazy. But not here, I feel safe."

To understand places like host bars, and professions like pole dancing, we rely on highly simplified cultural portrayals. Anywhere in the world, spaces like these can be embroiled in dark sexual politics, fetishisation and gender inequity. As the world swings to the political right, a movement that at its core seeks to control women and their bodies, watching any woman hold agency in any small way can feel like an incredibly powerful thing. Having fun, being loud, taking up space in a patriarchal society designed to make you feel small: these are all forms of resistance. Drinking lemon sours while watching men get kicked up the arse is a welcome bonus. *ralph*



Ralph Food Editor and global sandwich pioneer, Max Halley, reports from the corners of his gastronomic globe

“Most travel, and certainly the rewarding kind, involves depending on the kindness of strangers, putting yourself into the hands of people you don’t know and trusting them with your life.” Paul Theroux

Matamoros, the most north-easterly town in Mexico, sits over the US border to Brownsville, Texas, very close to where Elon Musk keeps his rockets. So close in fact, that when he lets one off, my wife’s family home, and presumably just about everything, shakes and quakes from the sheer, brutal power of the forces of nature being exploited.

Years ago, the month before my first visit to Matamoros, my wife Magali (then my girlfriend) wound me up mercilessly about the terrors of the cartels, the very-real-risk-of-kidnapping and the dangers just generally for ‘el gringo-gordo’ in the town her family call home. When we got there, my mother-in-law (also called) Magali and her mother Socorro were there to pick us up from the airport on the outskirts of town. Socorro gave me a cuddle, stepped back, and pretending to hold a machine gun, said “Welcome to Ma-ta-ta-tamoras.” Everyone laughed and I stood there like one of those rockets was ripping through the sky.

When debating whether to write about Matamoros, I wondered if it was appropriate to talk about somewhere I might not really recommend people to go, at least in the way I might Florence or New York or somewhere. If a visitor to England asked me where to go, I wouldn’t recommend the piece of rural Wiltshire where I live, because it isn’t

perceivably a tourist destination. But that doesn’t mean it isn’t wonderful, that they might not enjoy it and that I don’t think it one of the finest places on earth.

Mexico has been the *de rigueur* holiday destination of ‘discerning’ English people recently. Despite the much discussed merits of Mexico City, Oaxaca, San Miguel de Allende and so on, no one, not a single person, has ever told me that I “simply must go to Matamoros.”

The people who live there, at least the ones I know, joke constantly about the state of the roads, hold-ups at their local corner stores, the faded glories of the place and how great it was back when the Americans used to come to party there (big up García’s), not to just get fat hoovered out of their asses. Coming straight from Heathrow, rather than elsewhere in Mexico, ruled out Matamoros’ airport this year, so I changed at Dallas and got the tiny plane to Brownsville, Texas. My wife and daughter Coco were

waiting at the otherwise deserted baggage claim and after cuddles and so on, we drove the ten minutes to the border, Coco’s Spanish nursery rhymes blaring from our windows.

The border crossing here, over the Rio Bravo (Rio Grande to Americans), is romantic, exciting and an experience I relish. To many in Matamoros though, regardless of class/socio-economic background, it is as significant an event as taking out the trash. As long as they have the right visa, less hard to come by than you might imagine, people cross both ways, every day, often more than once, to work, visit family, take the kids to school, go to the gym or pop to the shops. Going from Mexico into the US, things are like most international

No one, not a single person, has ever told me that I “simply must go to Matamoros”

borders - bag scans, passport checks, mirrors under the car, intimidating encounters with armed Border Patrol agents and so on. Going from the US into Mexico though, is thrilling and surreal, because unless you are extremely unlucky, there are no obstacles in your way, literally none. You don’t even have to show a passport! It blows my tiny mind. “Mexico,” my wife always says, “everyone’s welcome.”

Once across, we meet up with the family and go straight to Los Portales, which means The Gates. If you like barbecued meat, particularly goat, these are the gates to heaven. Open since the early ‘60s, the restaurant is massive and run by a family of famous ‘charros’, (horse riders at the slick, athletic/gymnast end of the cowboy world). Full of taxidermied bull heads, decorative saddles and riding ephemera of all kinds, this is one of my favourite restaurants in the world. Meat is ordered by the cut (shoulder, ribs etc) and comes to your table on a dinky parrilla (a charcoal grill) so you can cook and determine the caramelisation and doneness of the meat yourself. Guacamole here is just mashed avocado, and there’s a similar lack of guff and garnish to all the food and the service. We begin, as always, with a plate of pickled pig skins (cueritos escabeche), all wobbly and wonderful. We eat them with extra jalapeño juice squeezed on, tortilla chips and onions from the liquor. This is followed by queso fundido (Oaxaca cheese, like a dry mozzarella), grilled on a plate, topped with crumbled chorizo and holder of the world record for ‘single greatest cheese pull in history’.

Magali’s family drink beers or Micheladas, the Mexican equivalent of a Bloody Mary and a far superior beverage. A glass of ice with a splash of Clamato juice (lighter than

tomato), Worcester sauce, lime juice, Tabasco and Maggi, topped up with the lager of your choice. Where the Bloody Mary gloops, the Michelada fizzes. I go for a Chelada, which is a beer, poured over ice with loads of lime juice and salt. It is delicious and ludicrously refreshing, especially when the weather is hot, which it is.

After lunch we head to Socorro’s house and sit in the garden beneath the avocado tree watching, and sadly listening, to the endangered Amazonian parrots sitting on a roof across the road. I put my feet up and

were it not for the racket, I could fall asleep, safe and secure in the bosom of my wonderful family.

We go back to our Airbnb via Soriana (a massive supermarket) to get my favourite hot sauce and bags of fresh tomatillos. Firm

and tight and still in their papery jackets, tomorrow morning I will char and blend them into a salsa with coriander, onion and fresh jalapeños. We come out of the shop and I see something I had forgotten. Here, in the heavily industrialised north, many still work long hours at hard physical jobs, and have neither the time nor equipment to cook much at home. Consequently, there are huge, manned BBQs run by the supermarket in the car park and if you bring them meat you’ve bought inside, they grill it for you for free, so you can take it home cooked. This, admittedly with meat from a posher butcher, is what tomorrow’s salsa is for.

Tomorrow comes, and once the salsa’s made, Magali, Coco and I head to the butcher and choose an array of thinly cut bits of beef, and thicker pieces of pork and chicken. We walk

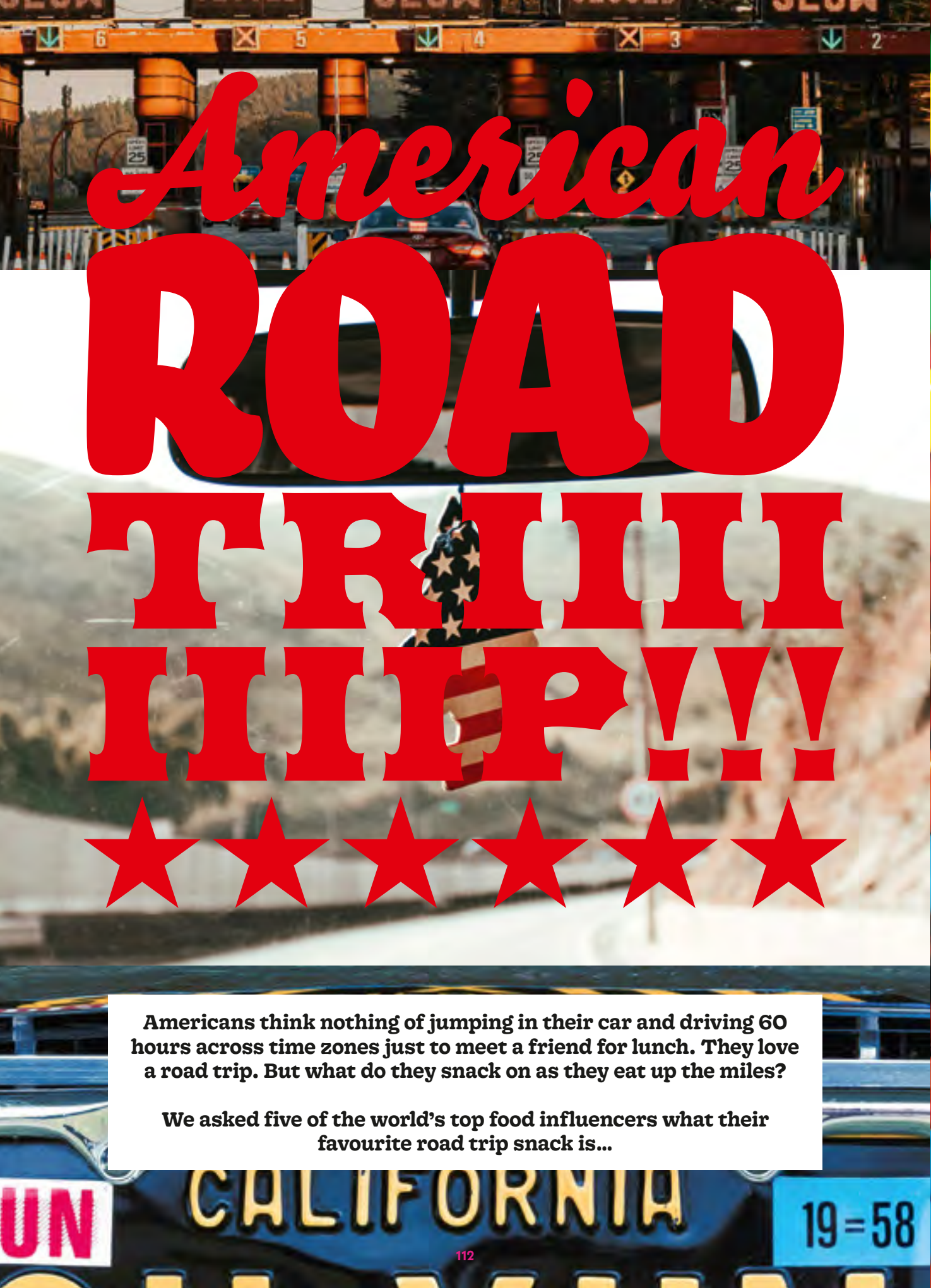
“Mexico,” my wife always says. “Everyone’s welcome.”

round the corner to the terrace of a restaurant closed until much later, where the butcher's chefs use the BBQ to cook their customers' meat. While we wait, we are given glasses, scooped from a huge Yeti, of iced hibiscus aquafresca and stand chatting to the men about the contrast between life in England and Matamoros, which local tortilleria is the best and whether corn or flour (wheat) tortillas are superior. There's no flavour like corn, but in the north, wheat features heavily. I wouldn't give one up for the other, but I love the flour ones. Thinner and less 'short' than corn, they are enriched with lard and, for me, take to grilling better.

A few days pass and it's time for lunch again. We're going to my favourite (and I think the best) taqueria in Mexico. El Ultimo Taco opened in 1982 and is owned by the uncle of Magali's childhood friend. If you've been to Taqueria Orinoco in Mexico City, this is cut from a similar cloth, but much, much better and if you look it up online, it is the el Ultimo Taco in Matamoros (not the one in Brownsville, six miles away). The offering is simple (or appears it) and their pastor is extraordinary. How they get away with that much cinnamon on something savoury, is a mystery I hope to investigate forever.

Wonderful as these places are, I cannot claim Matamoros a foodie Mecca, because it just isn't. This last visit, Magali got the worst food poisoning of her life and the city loves machacado with scrambled eggs, which I cannot abide. To beef what candy floss is to sugar, the stuff's a culinary abomination, but hey, it's a northern thing and what do I know? So, would I recommend you go to Matamoros? Could I tell you to choose it over Florence or wherever in Mexico some journalist's had a free holiday? Well, what with the chances of seeing a spaceship, the restaurant at the gates of heaven, Mexico's best taqueria and only the smallest risk of kidnap, it sounds like I might... *ralph*





American ROAD TRIP!!! ★★★★★

Americans think nothing of jumping in their car and driving 60 hours across time zones just to meet a friend for lunch. They love a road trip. But what do they snack on as they eat up the miles?

We asked five of the world's top food influencers what their favourite road trip snack is...



Aisha Ruperto

My go-to road trip snacks are peanut M&Ms, Zapps Voodoo potato chips, and a Diet Coke. This combo has everything I need with the sweet and salty combo and a DC to wash it down.

@foodgotmewasted

Brian Can't Stop Eating

My absolute go-to road trip snack has to be Lay's Barbecue potato chips. For one, they're definitely a top-three chip of all time but honestly, it's mostly the nostalgia factor. Growing up, my mom always had a jumbo bag packed for every road trip, so I've never strayed from that tradition. Now, I can't hit the road without them haha!

@briancantstopeating



Kaydee Church

Believe it or not it's beef jerky, hahah! I love the brands Chomps and Country Archer Provisions!

@kaydeechurch



Faith Fresh

I think the key to the perfect road trip snack is anything crunchy and salty. If I'm trying to be 'healthy', then I'd say my favourite snack is crackers and hummus. But if I'm being real, my favourite road trip snack of all time is Trader Joe's version of takis. The only problem with those is that I've never not eaten the entire bag in one sitting. I'd say they are my favourite because I spend the entire road trip looking forward to eating them... and for some reason, this anticipation makes the road trip more worthwhile to me. They have the perfect combination of crunch and flavour. Just make sure to pack napkins.... unless you want red smears all over your car hehe.

@faithsfresh



Salt Hank

I think black pepper sunflower seeds.

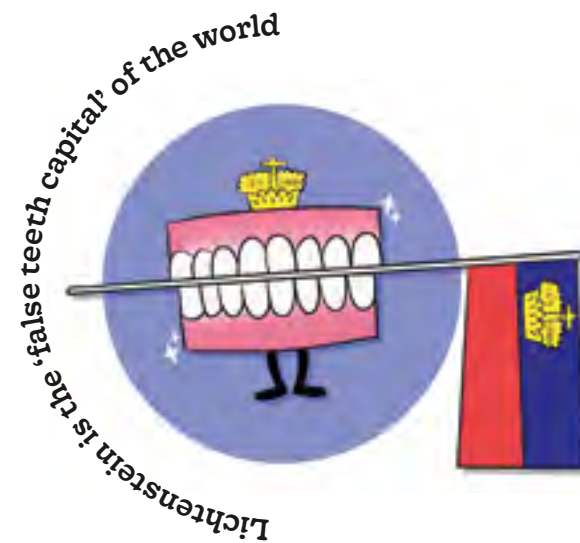
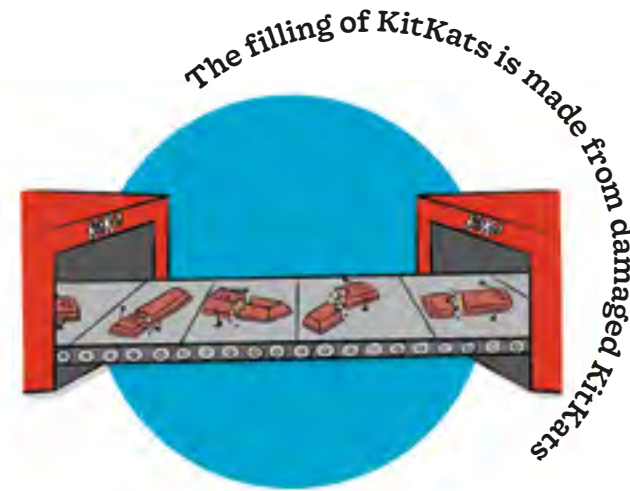
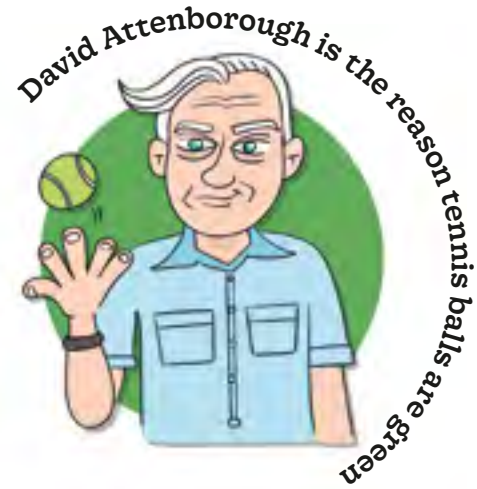
@salt_hank



DON'T GOOGLE THIS

Things we heard that might be true

Illustrations by Torey Strahl @toreystrahlcartoons



POPCORN PIRATE

We asked our mystery reviewer to review time itself

In this issue we venture from the ridiculous to the sublime and I've been tasked with reviewing the best Time. "But what does it mean?" I asked, I believe, quite reasonably. "Yes," Josh Jones replied. "Do that." And because I like an abstract challenge, here we are. You might not agree with what I've come up with but luckily for me IT'S RELATIVE.

6pm

6pm is for the righteous and the vagabond, for the young and free. It's also a generational marker and for anyone over 35, 6pm means *Fresh Prince of Bel Air*, *Boy Meets World*, possibly *Quantum Leap*.

Kairos/ Chronos

Let's start big in Ancient Greece – Kairos – the measure of time concerned with quality – Kairos measures life by its moments of great meaning or importance. Kairos is the counter of Chronos which is concerned with the sequential (BORING). Kairos is easily the more important and seductive of times, but also, like so many sexy things, not very useful when you've got a meeting.

Thyme

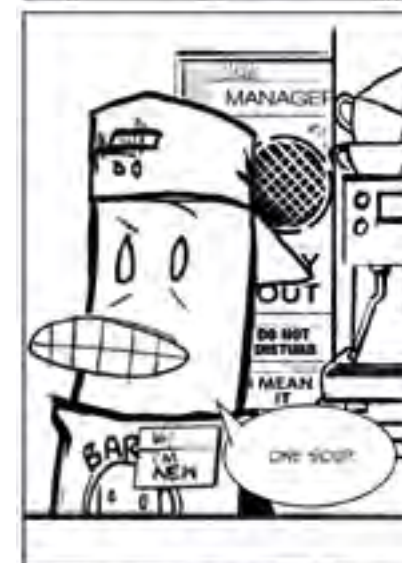
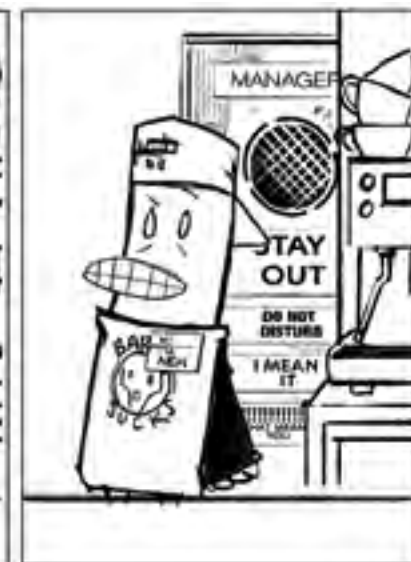
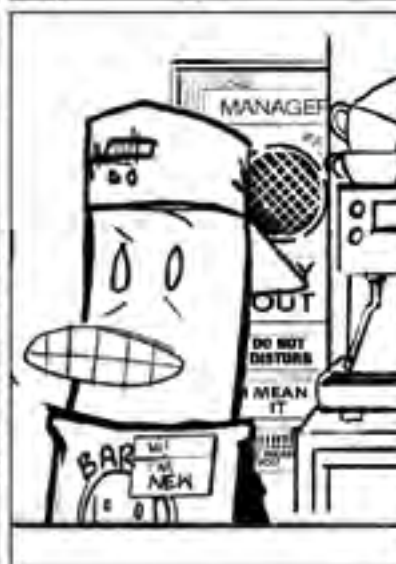
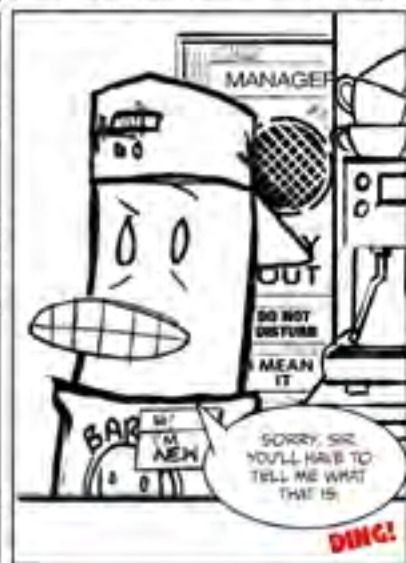
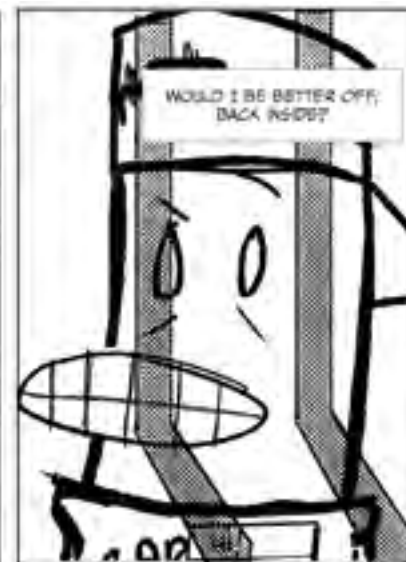
Thyme – Any friend of potatoes is a friend of mine.

Home time

Stay with me... Home time, oh home time, a changeable feast. How you feel about home time is a direct indicator of your era in life; in youth it's the greatest of times, the end of school, you still love your parents, you hate learning, it's 3 o'clock and all is well. In adulthood home time is the glorious gauge of independence – club boring? Home time. Work over? Home time. Good date? Home time with benefits. You're the master of your own domain and you can go there whenever and stay as long as you like. And then the stone-cold end, the words, uttered by your children who think you can't hear them – home time mother – as they wheel you out of your beloved family house for the last time, and up the ramp into the brick built casket where you will end your days.

One More Time – Daft Punk 2000

When I worked in a bar on a roundabout in Hammersmith I learned how to 'flare' – which is spinning bottles about on your arms a la Tom Cruise in *Cocktail* – the functioning alcoholic version of learning to juggle to get girls. I recorded myself doing this with 'ONE MORE TIME' as the soundtrack. Then I got my physicist boyfriend to write the physics out and I superimposed equations over the top of the flaring. Needless to say that 25 years later, this song makes me want to puke.



JOSH JONES & JEFF DEFINITELY



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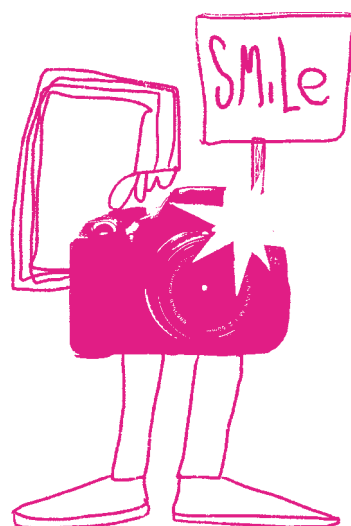
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